Maxwell Charles Davies

Commentary on a
Portfolio of Original Compositions

PhD Volume 2

This work is dedicated to Ceri, my fiancée. Her patience, understanding and unwavering support have been a constant source of encouragement, and without her this work would not exist.

I would also like to thank all friends and colleagues, both inside and outside Cardiff University School of Music, for their insight, suggestions, time and for simply being there when the need was great. I am eternally grateful.

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List of Works and Recordings

A Book of Firsts (2006) for soprano saxophone (or clarinet in B♭) and string quartet
(Recording of clarinet version: LCMG, Adrian Hull, Cardiff University, 28th March 2007)

A Rundown on Couples (2007) for violin and piano
(PM Ensemble: Rhys Watkins (violin), Andrew Wilson Dickson (piano), RWCMD, Cardiff, 13th March 2007)

Wild with Blue (2008) for alto saxophone and piano
(Amy Dickson (alto saxophone), Martin Cousin (piano), St Mary's Church, Painswick, Cheltenham Festival, 18th July 2008)

Are we in love? (2008) scena for soprano and piano
(Music Theatre Wales: Charlotte Ellett (soprano), David Seaman (piano), RWCMD, Cardiff, 9th November 2008)

3 Years (2009) drama for solo soprano

A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario (2009) "opera" for soprano, baritone and small ensemble
(Natalie Raybould (soprano), John Savournin (baritone), The Warehouse Ensemble, Tête à Tête Opera Festival, Riverside Studios, London, 13th August 2010)

The Mysterious Kiss (2009)
(Aldworth Philharmonic Orchestra, Andrew Taylor, Concert Hall, Reading Town Hall, 23rd January 2010)

Brunch (2007 & 2010-2011) opera for two sopranos, alto, guitar and optional actors

iD (2010-2011) for electric bass guitar

Doodles (2007-2011) four pieces for brass quintet
(Recording of movement two: *Sea Sick*, BBC NOW Chamber Ensemble, Mark Eager, Cardiff University, 16th February 2009)

Workplace Diary (2010-2011) for string quintet

Credo (2011) for SSAATTBarB choir

Introduction

A PhD in Music Composition is a self-contained period of creative research that is only one stage of a composer's lifelong journey. The music contained in the portfolio builds on what they have composed before; acknowledging that all their music is shaped by their cumulative experiences, interests and concerns. In addition, a PhD affords a rare compulsory opportunity for a composer to reflect on such matters through the writing of a contextualising commentary.

Whilst I believe that music itself serves as its own best explanation, it is an invaluable experience for any composer to afford interested parties an insight into their creative process. Such insight into the music of my portfolio requires knowledge of three things: relevant background information and influences, an assessment of my position in the wider context of contemporary music-making, and details of my compositional methods, processes and techniques. The first two points are discussed collectively in Chapter One. Chapter Two consists of focused discussions regarding my approaches to pitch and text, followed by detailed observations of my compositional methodology, incorporating my approaches to other musical materials. Chapter Three is an analysis of *The Mysterious Kiss* – a concerto for orchestra that employs most of the compositional processes explored throughout this PhD. The commentary closes with a postscript, detailing my conclusions as a result of this research, and plans for the future.

Chapter One

Background, Influences and Context

i) Early experiences

I was born into a non-musical family and brought up listening to my parents' eclectic collection of popular music. During early keyboard studies, I found myself able to play this style of music by ear. As new styles were encountered, my natural impulse was to play them by ear too. This ongoing practice led to an assured sense of harmony and harmonic directionality which remains at the centre of my compositional thinking.

Early exposure to classical music happened entirely outside my home environment[1]; at school and playing with county ensembles. A first encounter with Schoenberg's *Pierrot Lunaire* (1912) during GCSE Music completely challenged my perception of what music could be; all the more heightened by its parallel study with music of a different, but more familiar, world: a selection of songs from the musical *Les Miserables* (1980).

The study of Weber's *Overture to Oberon* (1826) and Smetna's *Vltava* (1874) from *Ma Vlast* at school was influential because it was the first time I encountered specific analysis of form and structure, as well as the idea of instrumental colour. In parallel, the senior county youth orchestra began programming pieces from the standard repertoire. The most significant pieces tackled in terms of my development as a composer were Mahler's *Sixth Symphony* (1906), Strauss' *Eine Alpensinfonie* (1915) and John Williams' *Star Wars Suite* (1977). To my young ears, all of these orchestral pieces inhabited a similar harmonic world[2] – one that I was interested in imitating. In some way, they were also associated with, or suggestive of, a narrative. The idea

[1] Occasional and undisciplined instrumental practice of classical pieces was undertaken at home. Although non-musical, my parents afforded me opportunities to learn many instruments. This is an ongoing interest and is still pursued. Many have been tried, with varying degrees of success, but each attempt in combination with an inquisitive interrogation of teachers, or other more competent players, gives an understanding of how to write idiomatically for an instrument. The acquisition of such knowledge is a lifelong endeavour.

[2] Being tonal works, it was possible to play (often simplified) versions of them by ear at the piano. In this way, the works occupied a similar harmonic world.

of writing music in response to a narrative, or extra-musical subject or concept, greatly appealed.

These early experiences culminated in the decision to pursue a career as a film composer. The *Star Wars Suite* was both film and concert music. This duality led to the conclusion that film music would reach a much wider audience; a seductive notion. A period of limited, informal and independent study of film music followed, focussing on the composers John Williams, James Horner and Jerry Goldsmith.[3] These scores seemed to be collages of varying styles; the music being whatever it needed to be in response to the film; their structures symbiotic, yet the music maintaining integrity of its own. This formed the mistaken conclusion that film composition consisted of the score paralleling the film exactly; telling the same story through suggestive, programmatic, and developing music that if separated from the film, would be a tone poem.

However mistaken my understanding of the film music industry was[4], this perceived approach to its composition – shaping pieces around narratives, and the music being whatever it needs to be with regards to styles and sounds – remains a major consideration from the outset of my compositional process. This is discussed further in the next chapter.

ii) Formal Studies in Higher Education

Four years of study with William Mival at the Royal College of Music were undertaken following A-Levels. During this time, continual questioning of what I wanted to express as a composer became, and remains, central. This was complemented by the study of a wide range of composers; their works, methods, approaches, techniques and processes.

[3] This consisted of watching films but focussing primarily on the music and how it was pieced together.

[4] Although the desire to become a film composer quickly dissolved as an undergraduate, Composition for Screen was taken as a module at the Royal College of Music during year four. This experience corrected any previous misconceptions about the nature of writing film music.

What stimulated both creative and intellectual interest was not the imitation of these techniques, but the more abstract concepts they offered; particularly those that readily allowed a more individualistic interpretation and adaptation. Many were studied – at times to a point of saturation that led to periods of creative incapacity – but the techniques that continue to distil and shape my music are outlined below.

My work is centred around controlling and maintaining strong relationships within pitch material. Serial processes were considered, but composing using them exclusively and exactly was of little interest. There were two attractive features of serial practice, however, that I became interested in compositionally at this time. The first was that repeated rows of pitches also represent repeated collections of intervals in a specific order. The second (although this treatment is clearly not confined to serial practice!) was the pre-compositional extension of pitch material by means of inversion, retrograde and retrograde-inversion. I became interested at this point in exploring the possibility of repeated patterns of intervals, combined with arbitrary uses of 'inversion, retrograde and retrograde-inversion,' maintaining an aural unity without the need for fixing pitch collections. Compositional experimentation involving this specific line of enquiry exclusively reached its conclusion in the first part of my PhD portfolio, and this is discussed in greater detail in the next chapter.

At the same time as this initial experimentation with modified serial techniques, exploration of the music of Lutoslawski, focusing on his approach to intervals, led to two discoveries. The first came about when studying the construction of twelve-note chords in his *Second Symphony* (1967); being linked to intervals:

> '…chords made up of one, two or three types of interval have a distinct, easily recognisable character…while chords that include all types of interval are devoid of colour and present no distinctive features.'[5]

[5] Tadeusz Kaczyński, *Conversations with Witold Lutoslawski*, trans. Yolanta May, Chester Music, (London, 1995), 60

What this instilled was a sense of the importance of intervallic choices when thinking both melodically and harmonically. The second discovery is one that I have incorporated in several pieces: the symmetrical chord. This was first encountered when examining his work *Subito* (1992).

A more crystalline, distilled and focused understanding (compared with undergraduate exploration) of a desired approach to intervallic unity, beginning with symmetrical chords, formed the starting point of my PhD research. The material of the first work composed, *A Book of Firsts*, comes entirely from the inherent potential of a single symmetrical chord. This is discussed in the next chapter.

As previously alluded to, my compositional processes are concerned with attempting to retain control over material. One final point pertaining to Lutoslawski's influence on my work is worthy of note, as it is in conflict with this: use of aleatory in structured compositions. This deliberately ensures a lack of control over certain elements. It was experimented with in a series of works prior to the PhD, in an effort to inject an element of freedom and unpredictability into the performance. It was my belief that this would enhance the expressive power of the music, but whilst 'freedom' was imposed on the performers, the resulting music did not sound free. In fact it sounded rather awkward and uncertain.

There were two outcomes of this. First was the realisation that an aesthetically attractive feature of certain aleatoric music – micropolyphonic textures – could be notated conventionally by superimposing different tuplets. Such textures continue to form a component of my musical language. The most comprehensive example of the employment of micropolyphonic textures to date is throughout the orchestral piece *Cells and Sanctuaries*, submitted for my Masters degree. During my doctoral studies, these textures were explored in a more conservative and focused way – as a means of creating moments of concentrated activity, in contrast with less dense

textures – and using smaller forces. Examples of this textural contrast can be found in the first and third movements of *Doodles,* and *Workplace Diary.*[6]

The second outcome was the realisation that there is a place for the use of aleatory in my idiom, but only when an idea cannot be expressed in any other way.[7] In the fourth movement of *A Book of Firsts*, an aleatoric approach is used to recall the music of the previous movement in an unfocused, distant manner. The brevity and context of this musical 'memory' dictated that aleatory was the most pragmatic approach to achieving the wanted effect.

Another technique discovered as an undergraduate was Per Nørgård's infinity series. Again, rather than the specific mechanics, applications thereof and resulting music, it was the offered concept, open to individual interpretation, that was of interest: an infinite series of intervals, offering infinite variation, yet maintaining a logical and strengthening unity within the material. It took four years to distil and experimentation is ongoing, but my interpretation and application of this concept using interval rows – far removed from Nørgård's rigorous, logical and inherently hierarchical technique – forms part of this research. This is discussed in the next chapter.

In addition to those composers mentioned thus far, it was those working in a more polystylistic (or related) idiom that offered example and potential models. Charles Ives' *Putnam's Camp, Reading, Connecticut* (1912) from *Three Places in New England* and Alfred Schnittke's *First Symphony* (1974) demonstrated different ways of superimposing numerous musics, and were a crucial starting point. These particular pieces, however, are heavily reliant on a certain element of pastiche, performer freedom, or heavy use of quotation which did not fit my desired approach.

[6] A five-part canon is initiated by the cello in bar 142, and once all five instruments are involved, the effect has an aleatoric flavour due to all five employed rhythmic divisions of a crotchet sounding simultaneously.

[7] The second section (setting the words 'forever unknown') of the chorale piece *Credo* was initially conceived with an aleatoric approach to give the impression of eight solo lines. When it was realised, however, a simple written description of the desired effect, in combination with conventional notation, was a clearer way of articulating what was wanted on the page.

It was Ives' *The Unanswered Question* (1906), where three distinct musical ideas are superimposed, which provided a more relevant model. Michael Tippett's *Third Symphony* (1972), which juxtaposes music of a more modernist idiom with his interpretation of blues, provided an example of the inclusion of a popular style. This was further consolidated when introduced to Peter Maxwell Davies' opera *Resurrection* (1987) where modernism, rock songs and television advert parodies are stitched together with transition passages. These transitions offered another concept that was eagerly assimilated: blending ideas by introducing gestures of one into the other to facilitate transition. Such an approach features greatly in the orchestral work *The Mysterious Kiss*, which is discussed and analysed exclusively in Chapter Three.

John Adams' *The Chairman Dances* (1985) has, to my ears, undertones of a more popular style. Having been brought up on a musical diet that consisted mainly of popular music, this work offered a first bridge between the classical and popular worlds.

Another considerable influence was Thomas Adès' orchestral work *Asyla* (1997), in particular the third movement; having flavours of popular dance and trance music, yet still remaining a perceived contemporary classical work written in a highly personal style. Similar to this is Tansy Davies' incorporation of funk in *Neon* (2004). Although a circuitous route, the attractive elements of these pieces, combined with a continuing fascination with Ives, led to discovery of the orchestral works of Elliott Carter.

Elliott Carter's music continues to beguile. One very seductive feature of his work is the juxtaposition, superimposition and integration of music of different characters. A particularly influential example was his *Variations for Orchestra* (1955), '…once

described by Aaron Copland as a monumental synthesis of many different kinds of modern music'[8] and '…based on Ives' technique of superimposition.'[9]

I have always considered all music to have 'character.' It is an invaluable means of interpreting music in a personal way. After encountering Carter's music, the consideration of musical ideas as characters became a conscious part of my compositional process, rather than considering such things in a microscopic manner, or labeling music as having a distinct character in hindsight.

During the development of every piece in the portfolio, musical ideas were viewed as characters. Two diverse uses of this 'character concept,' are demonstrated in *iD* and *Workplace Diary*. The musical characters in *iD* are linked to techniques associated with the bass guitar. As the work progresses changes from one to another become more rapid, contributing to an identity crisis. In *Workplace Diary*, actual people are represented with motifs derived from their mannerisms.

When conceiving of musical ideas as independent characters, my creative thoughts have turned to the theatre. Musical theatre has always formed part of my performing activities and therefore my musical consciousness. Indeed, all of the works in the portfolio were conceived both as dramas and as music. *A Rundown on Couples* and *Wild with Blue* are instrumental works that have inherent theatrical drama: the violin and alto saxophone respectively entering into a dialogue and relationship with the piano; all instruments treated in an anthropomorphic way.

iii) Playing and Performing

Prior to entering the Royal College of Music, my performing experiences were many and richly varied. As a principal study composition student, there was no performing provision apart from singing in the general chorus. As a result I experienced an abrupt reduction in ensemble playing.

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[8] David Schiff, liner notes from Elliott Carter, *Piano Concerto* and *Variations for Orchestra*, Cincinnati Symphony Orchestra, Michael Gielen, New World Records 80347, 1986, page 1 downloaded via http://www.newworldrecords.org/linernotes/80347.pdf accessed 02/03/2011

[9] *ibid.*

This affected composition in the sense that time was dedicated exclusively to study with no complementary ensemble music-making. 'Doing' in a musical sense became writing and collaborating independently with fellow students, who would perform or workshop the music. Although enriching, I felt that a certain connection to music, that is difficult to describe objectively, had been lost.

Whilst at Cardiff University, this missing connection has been remade. In addition to taking advantage of performance opportunities within the department, a more individual reconnection with music has occurred. I now have daily access to a personal piano; a privilege I did not enjoy as an undergraduate. Making music every day at the piano by freely improvising[10] is now an essential, expressive, visceral need that provides an immediate and individual connection to composition, and nurtures my creativity. As such, it is the integration of an improvisational freedom into structured compositional processes that remains one of my primary concerns.

iv) Improvisational influences

My improvisational style has evolved with changing interests and exploration of approaches to piano playing and writing. Early improvisational starting points were harmonically reminiscent of popular music, combined with gestures borrowed from the romantic piano repertoire. Later, a developing, complementary interest in self-learning jazz led to the formation of a performing jazz ensemble. This ensemble represents the majority of my current performing; playing a range of styles.[11] Playing jazz standards led to a more assured knowledge and application of functional harmony.

[10] Improvisation has always featured in my musical life, and indeed composition. It was a natural progression from playing music by ear to inventing similar material at the piano. Also, the piano remains an essential connection to sound during composition periods. At Cardiff University, however, the decision was made, after purchasing a piano, to give this activity a central importance in daily life, and to evolve a personal improvisational style complementary to my compositional voice.

[11] That same group also doubles as a salsa band – a recent development. Although quasi-pastiche, bossa nova-like music has been used in the portfolio: in the opera *Brunch* during the karaoke-like sections, and in the fifth movement of the brass quintet *Doodles*. These uses are deliberate for dramatic purposes; the latter to manage the expectations of the audience.

A relatively recent interest in jazz pianists, including Brad Mehldau and Kit Downes, has offered examples of the evolution of jazz piano that I am slowly attempting to understand through assimilation. Imitation of these pianists is difficult. All demonstrate an intense, immediate and individual musicality, combined with complete control over material. Some core melodic material can be deceptively simple, such as Downes' *Madame* (2009). The line is allowed to develop and unfold in a seemingly organic, intuitive way, into more complex versions, yet the shape and structure of the piece remain incredibly secure. This serves as a potent reminder, in my work, to let simple ideas remain thus; to not forget, when musically relevant within a piece, that 'less is more.' Mehldau's output includes arrangements of songs by The Beatles and Radiohead – two staples of my popular music diet. These arrangements serve as examples of 'cross-over' treatment – a seductive concept; it's integration into classical composition, under the umbrella of pluralism, being another of my aesthetic goals.

In parallel, certain works for piano shaped an evolving approach both to improvisation, and later to piano writing. Craig Armstrong's *Piano Works* (2004) was an album I was commissioned to transcribe for publication. It is mostly improvised, and tracks such as *Weather Storm* provided a first experience of notating fast, arabesque-like gestures. Two other works: Michael Finnissy's *English Country Tunes* (1977) and Elliott Carter's *Night Fantasies* (1980) were, when encountered in live performance, interpreted as essays in gesture – even drama – rather than attempting to aurally trace a musical line or shape. To be clear, it was not the scores of these pieces that were influential when writing for piano. It was directly observing the performance; the demands made of the pianist by the composer – both physical and in the required range of expression – that influenced my approach to improvising at the piano, and thus the character of certain musical ideas during composition.

'Gesture' became an important expressive consideration, and improvisation began to include more intuitively-driven gestures indebted to the Armstrong, Carter and Finnissy, although approached in my own way. These works unlocked possibilities

for piano playing that I had not previously considered. Composition and improvisation began to merge, as pieces (for any instruments) were initially conceived as a series of gestures, and immediately realised in shape and sounds through intuitive improvisation at the piano. This led to the discovery of the free, avant-garde improvisations of jazz pianist Cecil Taylor, which seem to be approached in a similar way: juxtaposing gestures of different characters and energies. The piano writing in both *A Rundown on Couples* and *Wild with Blue* was conceived in this manner. The latter consciously incorporates gestures discovered when playing jazz music. These piano parts are not notated improvisations; they were gesturally shaped through improvisation, but pitch decisions were systematically controlled using interval rows; a technique discussed in the next chapter.

Notating intuitive, sometimes gesturally complex, improvisations exactly was not how this visceral activity would become integral to my compositional methods. Experimentation with ways of combining this with an ever-growing armoury of developing techniques and approaches – assimilated from the formal study of other composers – form the foundations of the journey of this PhD.

v) Pluralism

My interest in jazz came about through playing, and use of it compositionally is still in its infancy. Putting such work into context has prompted a recent exploration of other composers whose music assimilates jazz in different ways. Carter's *Variations for Orchestra*, mentioned earlier, includes jazz as part of a synthesis of styles. Milton Babbitt's approach in *All Set* (1957) is to write idiomatically for jazz instruments – not only in gesture but also in structure – yet it is also a serial 'classical' work. To my ears, this music can be categorised as both. Other music of this ilk is that of Mark-Anthony Turnage, for example *Blood on the Floor* (1996) and his first opera *Greek* (1988). As with Adès' *Asyla* and Tansy Davies' *Neon* regarding popular dance and funk respectively, Turnage openly acknowledges jazz as a major influence in his language, yet does so in a highly personal way. None use mere pastiche.

Looking beyond jazz, another influence, whose multi-faceted influences and inclusions mirror that of classical composer counterparts already mentioned, is experimental rock music artist Mike Patton and his associated groups. Material is explored through use of disparate vocal techniques and allusions to music from many traditions. Two examples of such variety are the 1999 Mr. Bungle album *California*; a multi-influenced collage, incorporating many styles, ranging from Kecak-like chanting to the avant-garde. The second – Patton's 2010 album *Mondo Cane* – is made entirely of Italian songs from the 1950s and 1960s. He croons, but occasionally incorporates vocal techniques not usually associated with this genre, in a musically relevant way - such as screaming in *Urlo Negro*. I interpret this approach thus: the maximum expressive power, achieved through whatever musical device or style necessary, is always of central concern. I share, and aspire to, this ethos.

The desire to adopt a pluralistic approach to composition was borne from a combination of factors. The process began, albeit unconsciously, as soon as I became musically aware, and continues to develop. A naïve understanding of modernist ideals ('to create an individual universe that speaks to all humanity'[12]) was a starting point. My interpretation of universality however was not the creation of music that actively 'avoided signs and conventions from earlier styles'[13] to enable an understanding and discovery of meaning free from outside influence, but to combine (sometimes many) 'musical types with strong public associations'[14] to allow as wide an audience as possible to individually connect with the music as a whole, if only through certain strands initially. I came to learn that this was a way of thinking compatible with postmodernism. In *Postmodernism: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford, 2002) Christopher Butler discusses that by the late 1960s many composers had gravitated towards this kind of approach whilst not being directly inspired by

[12] Taken from Derek B. Scott's essay 'Music, Culture, and Society: Changes in Perspective', introduction to *Music, Culture, and Society: A Reader* ed. Derek B. Scott, Oxford University Press (Oxford, 2000), 3
[13] Susan McClary *Conventional Wisdom: The Content of Musical Form*, University of California Press (USA, 2000), 139
[14] *ibid.,* 147

postmodernist thought,[15] and I categorise myself as a composer whose pluralistic approach developed as a response to personal cultural experience, rather than any knowledge of postmodernist theory.

In composition I wanted to explore taking the musical elements that I liked from my eclectic listening habits and combining them in interesting, hopefully new, and certainly individual ways. As I said at the start of this commentary, my music is shaped by my past experience, and as a compositional tool this is akin to what Gilbert Adair describes, when musing on the past's role in creativity in contemporary culture, as a 'mammoth lucky dip. All you have to do…is plunge in and scoop out whatever happens to address your particular need.'[16] My 'particular need' as a composer is to find, through experimentation, new and interesting combinations that can, to borrow a description from John Adams, successfully 'cohabit' within a musical work.[17]

A striking example of such recombination can be found in the third movement of Luciano Berio's *Sinfonia* (1968-9). There is much quotation of existing works, all of which are, for want of a better label, classical, and therefore is not as relevant a model to my work as John Adams. But what Berio achieves, in my view, is a commentary on how interconnected these different works can be.[18] When discussing this movement, he says that 'these familiar objects and faces, set in a new perspective, context and light, unexpectedly take on a new meaning.'[19] In composition, I seek to employ the same approach and make new discoveries of meaning encompassing the eclecticism of my own musical tastes.

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[15] Christopher Butler *Postmoderdism: A Very Short Introduction,* Oxford University Press (Oxford, 2002), 73

[16] Gilbert Adair *The Postmodernist Always Rings Twice: Reflections on Culture in the 90s,* Fourth Estate (London, 1992), 17

[17] As described by John Adams discussing *Grand Pianolo Music* (1981-2), where 'Dueling pianos, cooing female sirens, Valhalla brass, thwacking bass drums, gospel triads and a Niagra of cascading flat keys all learned to cohabit as I wrote the piece' as quoted by Christopher Butler in *Postmoderdism: A Very Short Introduction,* Oxford University Press (Oxford, 2002), 85

[18] For a brief introduction to this movement see Butler (Oxford, 2002), 74, and also Berio's own liner notes from Berio *Sinfonia* and *Eindrücke*, New Swingle Singers and Orchestre National de France, Pierre Boulez, Erato 2292-45228-2, 1991

[19] Luciano Berio, liner notes, Erato 2292-45228-2, 1991

Another composer whose approach is comparable with my own is John Zorn. There are certain characteristics of his work that directly appeal to me as a listener, having much in common with the aforementioned band Mr Bungle.[20] In *Conventional Wisdom: The Content of Musical Form*, Susan McClary discusses aspects of Zorn's work that celebrate polystylistic nihilism without regrets, and describes his work as images that flash by in delirious succession. In addition, she quotes Zorn himself testifying that he has an incredibly short attention span and that in his opinion speed is taking over the world. His compositional voice was influenced by both this 'speed' and the music that he has been surrounded by since his childhood, including jazz, rock, classical, ethnic music, blues and movie soundtracks. I will address how this links to my own work from the point of view of my music's intended audience and modes of reception in the next section. Importantly, though, McClary observes that 'he refuses to abide by…the Great Divide between so called high and popular culture, for he is heir to both' due to his background and training.[21] This is the position that I firmly consider myself to be in as a composer, to the point where, for me, there is no distinction between the two, and those particular labels are rendered meaningless.

As an undergraduate, I did not have the confidence to simply juxtapose, superimpose or combine in other ways my interpretations of the various musics that I wanted to hear, and sought to manipulate and alter them beyond all recognition in my work due to a crippling (if, in hindsight, mistaken) sense of the sort of music that I *should* be composing in the context of studying contemporary classical composition. This process has continued to affect my work throughout my academic study, and the confidence to be true to my own musical wants without fear of institutional repercussions began to emerge in the latter half of the portfolio, particularly in *The Mysterious Kiss*, *Brunch*, *iD* and *Credo*. The earlier works were written with the same ideals in mind, but the perceived external factor of 'institutional reception' steered their composition toward a particular sound that perhaps was not what I initially truly wanted, but instead a combination of some of my individuality and what I

[20] In fact, Zorn co-produced Mr Bungle's eponymous first album of 1991, and has collaborated with Mike Patton on many occasions.
[21] See McClary (USA, 2000), pp 145-148

thought the music should sound like given my then context. I was acutely aware of this throughout. An important part of the journey of my PhD has been to emerge from it with these particular demons largely exorcised, not just in the more experimental works like *Brunch* and *Credo*, but also when writing for conventional ensembles in conventional settings.

vi) Musical Context

As all music evolves, and barriers dissolve between musical worlds, stylistic labels become more and more difficult to assign. Only performance contexts continue to divide perceptions of style, although these are becoming less rigidly defined.[22] As '…Alban Berg once said to George Gershwin: "music is music"'[23], and I believe that the only aesthetic criterion pertinent to appreciation that remains, beyond those of personal taste, is assessment of how well-crafted a piece is. If a work is well considered and executed by its composer, listening to what it has to say should prove a worthwhile investment.

The breakdown of musical barriers leads to two points of interest with regard to context. Each pertains to a different kind of barrier. The first is concerned with the dissolution of barriers that exist in all 'conventionally' made music, i.e. the organised containment of deliberately produced sound. John Cage offers, as a truth: '…that noise, when ignored, is disturbing, and when listened to, is fascinating.'[24] This, in combination with the idea behind his (perhaps most famous) work *4'33"* (1952) – that all sounds could be interpreted as music – provides a far-reaching relevance for the necessity of any music that is composed, but more for composers than listeners. This is to say that if noise is 'needed,' and noise is music, then music must therefore be 'needed.' Any composer despairing as to the relevance of their music to others need only be reminded of this to dispel any creativity-stifling negativity.

[22] Nonclassical club nights are an example of this phenomenon, where (according to the nonclassical website) 'contemporary classical music is presented as if it were Rock or Electronic music – breaking out of the constraints of the traditional classical concert hall and possibly creating a new genre in the process.' See http://www.nonclassical.co.uk/?page_id=2 accessed 09/01/2012

[23] Alex Ross, *The Rest is Noise*, Harper Perennial (USA, 2009), xv

[24] *ibid.*, xvi

The second 'barrier' is one that surrounds any particular genre in relation to demographics. Such a barrier separates many people from contemporary music, and in particular, opera.[25] This commentary is being penned at the time of the premiere run of Turnage's *Anna Nicole* at the Royal Opera House. On discussing contemporary opera he ponders its relevance to a modern audience,[26] and in a recent interview distributed through his publisher's website, he says:

> 'I think opera will survive if it connects to "now". I don't mean it has to always be a CNN-opera but it has to engage with issues of contemporary relevance.'[27]

Another recent opera that connects to contemporary issues is Tod Machover's *Death and the Powers* (2010). Unprecedented use of technology enables a theatrical portrayal of a consciousness uploaded into a sophisticated computer system, as well as robotic interaction for the human cast.

Both these works deal with the social relevance of opera in different ways. Their exposure, however, poses practical and economic challenges, as well as associations (the opera house/ticket price) that will still impose barriers on certain demographics. *Brunch* circumvents all of these issues, and serves as a summation of my developing concerns regarding performance contexts, and relevance of contemporary music. The setting is a café which employs a resident artist. The subject matter is an ordinary conversation between three friends, who are visiting the café as customers. The remaining clientele – an unsuspecting and unknowing audience – are invited to, as happens frequently in life, eavesdrop on this conversation, which develops with unexpected twists, turns and humour designed to inspire, engage and maintain interest. In parallel, the music carries the drama. Complex melodic lines are juxtaposed with dramatic use of barbershop, karaoke music, and mobile phone ring tones. The barriers of performance place are lifted, as the work, written for

[25] This is a personal observation based entirely on continual, informal questioning of friends, colleagues and acquaintances, many of whom do not work in music.
[26] Nicholas Wroe, *Mark-Anthony Turnage: A life in music*, The Guardian: Guardian Review, 22nd January 2011, 12
[27] Mark-Anthony Turnage, *Mark-Anthony Turnage interview:* Anna Nicole *at the opera (February 2011)* read via http://www.boosey.com/cr/news/Mark-Anthony-Turnage-interview-Anna-Nicole-at-the-opera/12193 last accessed 02/03/2011

economic and portable forces, has a performance option influenced by the 'flash-mob' phenomenon:[28] with an establishment's permission, it can simply be performed there by the four[29] musicians as soon as it is learnt. A kind of opera, yet crucially not labeled as such (or indeed in any way), will be experienced, but entirely outside of its familiar context. It will simply happen in a seemingly spontaneous manner. The musicians never leave their characters as customers, but exit as it is written into the drama. In this way, all who are involved remain anonymous, and for the audience, the performance remains part of that day's unplanned fabric. If an interest has been inspired, enquiries can be made to the establishment, who will have details of the work. It is my hope that an interest in innovations in other fields of contemporary music will develop for those people.

This is perhaps ambitious, but the ability for contemporary music to encompass a multitude of listening approaches, by the inclusion of personal responses to different styles, is a current driving force behind my work. It is my belief that the more 'ways in' to contemporary music afforded to any audience, the more relevance it will have to music lovers.

There are many people who view contemporary music as elitist and abstruse.[30] Composers certainly should not compromise their musical languages by making works 'less challenging' and more 'familiar,' but I believe in the possibility of compromising strategies to bring it to a wider audience. I express my ideas and beliefs in music and wish to share them, as do other artists, with as many people as possible. The notion that my music has potential relevance for many, and in particular non-musicians, directly influences its composition.

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[28] As an example I cite a Christmas Flash Mob performance of Handel's Hallelujah Chorus on 13th November 2010 in the USA. This can be seen online at http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SXh7JR9oKVE accessed 11/12/2011

[29] There is an option for just the three singers to perform the work, but only if they all have perfect pitch.

[30] Again, this is based on my own observations and experiences. Alex Ross discusses this particular state of affairs and offers some possible solutions in his 2010 article *Why do we hate modern classical music?* See http://www.guardian.co.uk/music/2010/nov/28/alex-ross-modern-classical-music accessed 09/01/2012

A parallel to this in the visual art world is Cindy Sherman's *#228* (1990), discussed by Christopher Butler (Oxford, 2002) and he goes on to quote Sherman directly: '[she] wanted to make something that anyone off the street could appreciate.'[31] This is exactly how I would describe my intended audience, and particularly non-musicians. The description 'off the street' is also telling of my intended modes of reception, in that, as in *Brunch* and also *Credo*, these works are not intended for the theatre or concert hall respectively (although their performance in such spaces is not precluded), but to simply occur in the background and provide an invitation for people to engage with it should they wish. These ideas regarding intended audiences, performances and social function require contextualization, which I will now attempt to do by drawing on extant socio-cultural scholarship.

In her essay *On Musical Experience* Lucy Green observes that 'music is divided into styles with appropriately related listeners' and goes on to explain mechanisms of meaningful understanding (familiarity, recognition of disturbance and resolution).[32] In the same volume, similar issues of meaning and familiarity of style are also discussed by Derek B. Scott[33] and Allan F. Moore.[34] In *Why Music Moves Us* Jeanette Bicknell discusses a different perspective on meaning, namely how listeners from various cultures 'have little trouble judging the emotional expression of music,' and, from an interested if less invested point of view, the more complex psychological processes surrounding *how* music achieves this, as social rather than individual experience.[35] I conclude, therefore, from a compositional perspective, that the incorporation of many styles as discussed above will appeal to *and* have at least *some* inherent meaning, based on these ideas, to a wide audience.

The theory of my intended modes of reception draws on many writers' observations and conclusions. Firstly, with regard to my aim to explore 'meaningful' background music that becomes part of a day's unplanned fabric, Gilbert Adair observes

[31] Butler (Oxford, 2002), 97
[32] See Scott (Ed.) (Oxford, 2000), pp 157-160.
[33] *ibid.,* pp 12-13
[34] *ibid.,* pp 161-163
[35] See Jeanette Bicknell *Why Music Moves Us*, Palgrave Macmillan (USA, 2009)

(discussing reproduced art via mass media) that 'culture will increasingly come to us…and something that will 'happen' to us increasingly…in…our own space.'[36] This is something that I wish to pursue with live music in a variety of public arenas, and one possibility of how to achieve this within the current economic climate is discussed later in this chapter. Adair also describes contemporary culture as a 'haemorrhage of images'[37] and Butler describes the internet, which I believe to be representative of my understanding of contemporary culture as 'a non-hierarchized, indeed disorganised, collage.'[38] Put another way, there is too much choice, and with increasing dissemination of information and ideas comes a seemingly increased pace of life. Choosing what 'new' events to attend or things to purchase can be difficult.[39] In his essay *Towards an aesthetic of popular music* Simon Frith concludes that personal preference (choice making) is socially determined by trends, which in turn shapes our identity (a common sense viewpoint of contemporary culture in my view). He goes on to say that

> 'It may be that, in the end, we want to value most highly that music, popular and serious, which has some sort of collective, disruptive cultural effect. …Music only does so through its impact on individuals. That impact is what we first need to understand.'[40]

It may seem an absurdly obvious thing to say, but there will be no impact on individuals if the music is not experienced, and this has led to my belief in the need to bring my live contemporary classical polystylistic music directly to people, in their own personal 'space' (outside of the home) – to give them the option of leaving rather than having to make the choice to attend. By making observations of its impact I'll be in a position to evolve my compositional approach based on this empirical trial and error.[41]

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[36] Adair (London, 1992), pp 20-24
[37] Adair (London, 1992), 17
[38] Butler (Oxford, 2002), 117
[39] I have both experienced and observed this on many occasions.
[40] See Richard Leppert and Susan McClary (Ed.) *Music and Society: The politics of composition, performance and reception*, Cambridge University Press (Cambridge, 1987), pp 133-149
[41] In his essay *On Popular Music and Postmodernism,* Andrew Goodwin quotes a particularly pertinent passage from Georgina Born regarding the relative success of postmodern synthesis and that it 'must be based on empirical study…rather than making facile assertions, it is necessary to analyse real socio-economic and aesthetic differences that exist.' See Scott (Ed.) (Oxford, 2000), pp 221-224

With my intended audience and performance scenarios now established, I shall turn to the role of the listener and this music's intended functions. But before I can discuss the role of the listener, I must theorise as to possible mechanisms of attracting listeners in the first place. In *Music in the era of electronic reproducibility*[42] John Mowitt

> 'engages the famous Adorno-Benjamin debate that centred on the cultural experience of mechanically reproduced art and the political implications of the difference between art to be received in a state of contemplation (traditional art forms)…and that ideally received in a state of 'distraction' (mechanically reproduced art)'[43]

I am placing my 'live background music' in the same socio-cultural category as 'mechanically reproduced art,' and its ability to, as I've already quoted from Gilbert Adair 'come to us.' I align myself with Benjamin's conclusions regarding the state of 'distraction' rather than Adorno's, in that 'one [can] make sense of [art] without surrendering to its traditionally sanctioned patterns of identification.'[44] Listeners will be able to recognise elements within a polystylistic collage and make sense of the whole through these inherent individual meanings.[45]

Regarding the elements that they do not recognise ('disturbances,' see page 18), it is my hope that, to use Benjamin's labels, it is possible to 'distract' listeners, through the presence of stylistic differences, into a state of 'contemplation,' even if this is not (at first, at least) particularly long lasting. I accept that a listener may not need to experience an entire piece in order to get what they want out of it, and fully endorse a 'dip in and out of' approach to it.

In *On Music and its Reception* Pierre Boulez postulates that 'indifference on the part of the listener toward contemporary music might…be due to laziness, to inertia, to the pleasant sensation of remaining in known territory' and goes on to discuss the

[42] Leppert and McClary (Ed.) (Cambridge, 1987), pp 173-197
[43] *ibid.,* xvii
[44] *ibid.,* 185
[45] As a composer I am also interested in incorporating in every piece as part of its strategy (although not by means of pastiche) tunes that catch one's attention – so called 'earworms,' or as the neurologist Oliver Sacks calls them 'brainworms.' See Oliver Sacks *Musicophilia: Tales of Music and the Brain,* Picador (Oxford, 2008), pp 44-53

need to invest time in many repeated hearings to gain a meaningful understanding of a contemporary musical work.[46] I agree *in theory* from the point of view of a trained composer, but in practice, when I am listening intently, I try to recognise familiar elements, and in this way gain meaning. I purposefully offer familiar elements to my intended audience in the hope of inspiring intent listening and interest. In addition it is, realistically, incredibly unlikely that said audience will invest their private time in repeated hearings, at least for the foreseeable future. In order for this to happen, awareness of contemporary classical music as an entity needs to be increased, which is another aim of my desired 'live background music' approach. Michel Foucault has made some observations regarding this that represent my beliefs. He says that 'the most [frequently experienced music] becomes the most acceptable, and soon the only thing perceivable.' I relate this to various popular styles, and possibly easy jazz too, and this is another reason for including personal responses to these in my compositional strategies. With regard to increasing awareness, he talks of 'derailing familiarities,' and that 'it is not a matter of making access to [the most frequently experienced] music more rare, but of making its frequent appearances less devoted to habits and familiarities.'[47] This is precisely what I am attempting to do.

If successful, and listeners are attracted to the music, what function will it serve? I've already discussed its potential role in increasing awareness of contemporary music, and endorsed a non-obligatory 'dip in and out' listening approach.[48] But it is my hope that listeners will be inspired to stay until the end of a piece, or through at least one complete cycle if it is a repeating loop, like *Credo*. I believe that a changing, plural musical landscape may well keep an audience interested.[49] My desire, therefore, is that the music will be socially functional, in that, depending on the

[46] Scott (Ed.) (Oxford, 2000), pp 166-167
[47] *ibid.,* 165
[48] Andrew Goodwin muses on the space in contemporary pop occupied by composers Philip Glass, Brian Eno and Laurie Anderson, yet the reverential behaviour of the audience has more in common with a classical music audience rather than a 'singing along, moving around' pop audience. See Scott (Ed.) (Oxford, 2000), 223
[49] John Shepherd makes an observation that the strategy '[of moving] between voice types in performing a song in order to keep an audience interested' is employed by popular female artists in *Music and male hegemony*. See Leppert and McClary (Ed.) (Cambridge 1987), 171

music's character, it can provide a backdrop for personal reflection during the course of a busy day, or provide entertainment,[50] but ultimately, as Susan McClary describes, as it is 'put together from elements recognisable to a substantial community of listeners, that it should participate in a public arena where interpretation is actively provoked.'[51]

I believe that of all umbrella styles, it is contemporary classical music that has the greatest capacity for pluralism, and therefore the largest palate from which to draw when expressing an idea in music. In a way, it is a different kind of contextual pluralism that makes other musics more accessible: inclusion of easily-understandable lyrics in songs, an easily-followed story in musical theatre, or a dance floor, for example. These are ingrained into the social fabric because of their perceived accessibility, engagement of the other senses, and complementary activity. One strategy that I have adopted in this PhD is to choose subject matter that is easy to relate to, or 'everyday.' *A Rundown on Couples* and *Wild with Blue* depict two people interacting in familiar ways (arguing and dancing, for example), while *Workplace Diary* depicts an office environment; the people, as well as the ambient sounds such as humming computers (bars 75-84), a boiling kettle (bars 112-123), and a ringing telephone (first appears in bars 270-289). It would be my preference in performances to point these out specifically to any audience, either as a demonstration during a pre-performance talk, or a looping-film in the performance space depicting the source sounds and their musical results. This will give a potential listener insight into my creative process, and will show them that this music is based on everyday encounters, giving them a way in if they are interested. Ideally, this space would not be a conventional concert hall, but an informal hub of social activity during which the music will just happen, as discussed above. To briefly revisit the discussion of John Zorn, Susan McClary observes that the musical structure of *Spillane* (1986) parallels those found in urban pulp fiction, and therefore listeners acquainted with this narrative schema will, despite a ruptured and eclectic surface,

[50] Allan F. Moore discusses the function of music in *On the Pop-Classical Split*, and introduces the ethnomusicologist Alan Merrium's ten categories of music's functionality, the third of which is entertainment. See Scott (Ed.) (Oxford, 2000), pp 161-163

[51] McClary (USA, 2000), 141

be able to trace the background trajectory.[52] The strategies I have described above, therefore, are intended to acquaint a listener with the narrative schema of my works (made up of everyday and familiar components), but this process itself forms a part of the performance, albeit an elaborate pre-performance, designed to educate.

One final point regarding my perceived context as a composer of pluralistic contemporary classical music, with a desire to promote such music as a 'background' component of everyday experience, is writing for, and working with, dedicated amateurs. From a purely economic point of view they play for love rather than money, and so the possibilities of pursuing experimental projects away from the arena of the music profession and free from financial hurdles is incredibly attractive. With so many composers vying for professional exposure, but relatively few opportunities available, it is an exciting time to be forging relationships with local musicians, having a dedicated audience, and taking the time to work with them on one's own music. This can be very musically fulfilling, as I experienced when writing *The Mysterious Kiss*; a commission from an amateur orchestra.

[52] See McClary (USA, 2000), 144-145

Chapter Two

As stated in the introduction, this commentary shall concentrate on three areas. Having discussed my background/influences, and position in the context of contemporary music-making, I will now examine my compositional concerns and methodology.

Pitch

i) Introduction

As mentioned in the previous chapter, an assured sense of harmony and harmonic directionality is the central concern of every piece. Ultimately, my musical intuition is the governing force over pitch decisions. Early on, I discovered that writing purely intuitively did not constitute the full extent of the craft of musical composition. Intuitive invention gives birth to new ideas, but it is the intellectual side of composition – the use of processes and techniques – that allows a composer to rigorously explore these ideas from any angle, and generate related material. The main concern during my doctoral research has been to explore this fusion of the head and heart by the development of processes that allow two things: to maintain control over, and ensure an aural unity within, pitch material, and to simultaneously allow a level of perceived intuitive improvisational freedom.

In addition, it is necessary to acknowledge the two forces behind seemingly intuitive choices regarding pitch, that seem in conflict with an employed method or technique. The first is the notion that these methods can be fluid. They are incorporated into the compositional process and music is created. The resulting music has inherent flavours and characters that are absorbed by a composer during its composition. That initial music owes its existence to the creative use of the process, but at times during its composition, the music needs to do something contrary to what that technique suggests. These deviations are guided by the composer's intuition, but are inextricably linked to the flavours and characteristics of that initial music. The relationship between intuition and technique graduates to one of symbiosis during the composition of a work; the music is created, and sounds complete, as a result of both.

The second force governing intuitive choices is formative experience. What sounds 'right' is the result of years of exposure to music. In my case this was mostly tonal music and, as a result, I always listen to and attempt to understand and explain any music from the point of view of functional harmony. It has become an involuntary reflex. In addition to employing techniques, tonal relationships have become an important conscious consideration when making decisions about harmony and melody. Strong voice leading is also a concern with regard to the directionality of both of these elements.

ii) Interval Rows

a) Origins, context and basic premise

The conceptualisation of pitch material as rows of intervals, rather than specific, fixed pitches, came about when searching for a fluid, yet rigorous way of exploring any idea expressible as a linear collection of pitches, and the ability to generate infinite amounts of related material.

The adoption of thinking in infinite terms is indebted to Per Nørgård's melodic infinity series. 'Taking a single interval as DNA,'[53] the series self-generates in a manner as if it already exists. It does not allow for intuitive choice of pitch, only its intuitive use. I felt that this fixed too many pitch and structural decisions before the composition of a work had even begun. The melodic infinity series did, however, provide a context for a technique that embraced rows containing repeating intervals, in both original and inverted form, and repeating pitches. The 'infinite' aspect of my musical thinking was neither absolute nor linked to this kind of mechanistic process that would self-perpetuate. It was rather the ability for something fixed to be endlessly repeated, but never in exactly the same way – akin to the idea of 'mutation' when related to the DNA analogy. My hypothesis was that pitch possibilities could be presented as options, generated via related intervals, and intuitively chosen from.

[53] This analogy and an introduction to the infinity series is detailed in Erling Kullberg's essay 'Beyond Infinity' trans. James Manley, in *Music of Per Nørgård* ed. Anders Beyer, Scolar Press (England, 1996), pp. 71-93

This notion of 'infinitely varied repetition' is partly indebted to the inherent unity in pitch collections present in serial works; achieved due to the repetition of rows and their permutations. Again, even the basic twelve-tone serial method fixed too many pitch parameters during the pre-compositional stage for it to be of relevance to my wanted approach. During a very brief period of experimentation with twelve-note serialism, I thought of rows as a series of intervals, to facilitate quick calculations of their inversions, rather than as a series of specific pitches. This, in combination with Lutoslawski's notion of intervals having a specific flavour, shifted importance onto the intervals connecting the pitches, rather than the actual pitches themselves. It occurred to me that the 'fixed' material, that could be ever-present through endless yet varied repetition and thus maintaining unity, could be an ordered series of specific intervals, removed from any fixed association with certain pitches.

Nørgård's infinity series contributed the idea of rows based on repeating intervals, expressed in both directions. Serialism, Lutoslawski and Nørgård combined, contributed the idea of establishing an order of wanted intervals that could be endlessly repeated in an infinite number of variants.

The key for finding a way to increase the number of possible variants of material resulting from an interval row, lay in how it was to be interpreted. The precedent for the solution was found when Stravinsky's late serial works, composed using his 'system of hexachordal transposition-rotation,'[54] were encountered. When analyzing use of this in *Abraham and Isaac* (1963), Stephen Walsh observes '…the grid mechanism could in theory run indefinitely, but Stravinsky limits himself to a kind of sampling process.'[55] The mechanism's potential indefinite quality was closer to my interpretation of 'infinity,' and the sampling process was a seductive example of an intuitive-like use of technique. Interval rows were conceived as cycling indefinitely, the possibilities suggested by the row could then be 'sampled,' and a final choice would progress the piece one pitch at a time.

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[54] Timothy J. Buell, *The Harmonic Language of Stravinsky's* Abraham and Isaac, ex tempore, Vol. V/1 (Spring/Summer 1989) read via http://www.ex-tempore.org/buell/BUELL.htm last accessed 27/02/2011

[55] Stephen Walsh *The Music of Stravinsky*, Clarendon Press (Oxford, 1988), 262

In order to generate more possible pitches from which to sample, the decision to unfix interval directions (up or down) as a parameter when moving from pitch to pitch following an interval row's instruction was made. Any interval encountered in the row could also be interpreted either as it is stated, in inversion, or, where applicable, major or minor forms.

Ergo, when following an interval row through during composition, its instruction can affect both melodic and harmonic decisions when relating notes to each other, using the following rules:

- a third (minor [3-] or major [3+]) could be either a third (minor or major) or a sixth (minor [6-] or major [6+]) in either direction, and vice versa
- a second (minor [2-] or major [2+]) could be either a second (minor or major) or a seventh (minor [7-] or major [7+]) in either direction and vice versa
- a perfect fourth [4] could be either a perfect fourth or a perfect fifth [5] in either direction and vice versa
- Repeated notes [-] could be either repeated notes or repeated at the octave [8] in either direction, and vice versa
- a tritone [TT] would remain a tritone, in either direction
- all of the pitches sounding at any given moment can be considered when choosing the next pitch for any instrument

This multitude of possibilities gave the desired sense of intuitive, improvisational freedom. Additionally, the flavours of the interval rows are absorbed. Decisions that conflict with the interval row become more frequent as composition progresses, but the results of these decisions remain true to the characteristics of both the interval row and the piece.

b) Extraction of interval rows

Unlike Nørgård's infinity series and serial works, where the respective rows are the first pitch materials to be created during pre-composition, interval rows are a means of extracting the intervallic components from improvised material. The

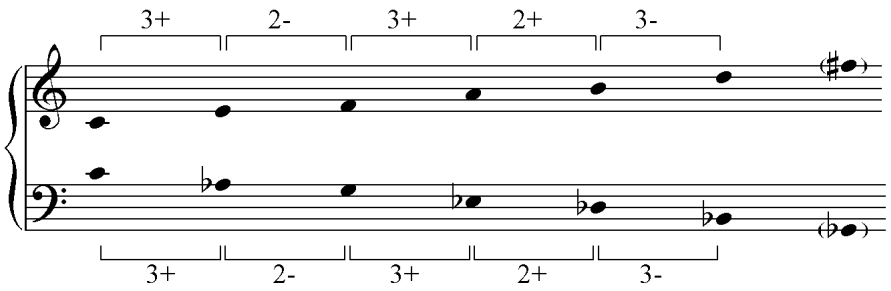
improvisation, therefore, contains the core material, or 'spark,' and the extracted material forms the foundations onto which a much larger piece can be built; propagating and simultaneously unifying all subsequent music composed.

The extraction method is as follows. Once the core material for a piece has been identified, its intervallic content is examined. The order in which the intervals appear is then expressed as an interval row, by writing them out using letters, numbers or symbols in an order. This chosen order depends on the nature of the idea. If it can be expressed as a single line of music, then the order of the intervals can be extracted in a linear fashion. When a core idea consists of multiple lines, however, there are both horizontal and vertical intervallic relationships to consider. How these are extracted to form logical interval rows that are faithful to the flavour of the original material requires exploration of, and experimentation with, all of the resultant possibilities. The number of these possibilities depends on the density of the original material.

c) Uses and developments

Interval rows were first used by myself in *A Book of Firsts*. This is the only work composed using this technique where the core material was artificially constructed in the form of a symmetrical chord. This is because the core material had already been decided upon, and the opening music had already been composed, before interval rows were considered as a result of a period of writer's block. Even though the technique had been forming in my conscious thoughts for some years, this was the first time it was employed.

Example 1 shows the core material of *A Book of Firsts* and analysis of its intervallic components.



Example 1: The symmetrical chord that is the core material of *A Book of Firsts*; the intervals that formed interval rows are labeled.

From this pitch material, the following two symmetrical interval rows were extracted:

A.	3+	2-	3+	2+	3-	3-	2+	3+	2-	3+
B.	3-	2+	3+	2-	3+	3+	2-	3+	2+	3-

The first page of the work and the saxophone-viola duet in the fourth movement are made using the note relationships from the symmetrical chord. The rest of the piece is made by using these interval rows; the way in which they are themselves used is very experimental in nature. Examples include the saxophone flourish in bar 11 which was written using row A broken down into sections. The ensemble at bar 14 (Figure B) is split into two groups; the intervallic relationships between the notes of the saxophone and cello follow row A, then row B – in combination treated as a single row, and the cello is following row A on a loop. The chords in the violins and viola, reading from the bottom to the top, follow overlapping groups of two intervals from row B. In the second movement, the fast saxophone melody uses both rows combined, and the string accompaniment is made of material suggested by the flavours inherent in the limited number of intervals employed, again using repeating smaller blocks of the two rows. In the third movement, the melody, shared between all four string instruments, starting at bar 49 (Figure H) follows row A. The harmonisation of this melody also follows the intervals of row A.

This experimental use of interval rows in *A Book of Firsts* was successful as a means of generating and maintaining control over pitch material; the music sounding

unified, yet written with a degree of intuition. The arbitrary employment of them, however, was unfocused, even haphazard. Although partially justified by the brevity of the movements, this casual approach was still largely reliant on intuition, rather than intuition and process having near-equal importance. This led to a further period of experimentation extracting interval rows from more spontaneous and intuitively improvised music, and then composing whole works based on these seminal ideas.

The core material for *A Rundown on Couples* is the first twelve bars of the violin part. When I was examining the melody in preparation for extracting an interval row, it was quite clear that, being a long melody and not a small, germinal idea, development of much smaller cells that made up the melody as a whole was already occurring. Rather than pick apart the melody and its individual cells, I decided to evolve the notion of interval rows and express the properties of this melody as a 'cells row.' The treatment of this new kind of row would be exactly the same as an interval row; control of pitch material and unity achieved by the varied repetition of these distinctive cells in the first order established. It was this fixed order that provided the stability that was not present in the interpretations of the interval rows of *A Book of Firsts*.

Example 2 shows the opening thirteen bars of *A Rundown on Couples* with an analysis of the component cells of the violin melody, and how these are used in the same order to make the piano part.



Example 2: The opening thirteen bars of *A Rundown on Couples* with analysis.

The choices made when composing the piano part were affected not just by the piano's previous notes, but also the violin part. The rest of the piece in terms of making pitch decisions progressed in the same manner; largely following the initial order of the cells as they appear in the violin and using them to craft the music in relation to all the pitches that are sounding – thereby relating everything. Again, there are times when, for musical reasons, the row is not followed exactly, but the intuitive decisions are faithful to the characteristics of the initial pitch material.

The use of 'cells rows' was continued in *Wild with Blue.* This represents the most ambitious use of the technique in the portfolio. It is also the last work to use rows exclusively in this way. The work was originally requested as a short 'tour de force' for clarinet and piano, between five and six minutes in length. As with *A Rundown on Couples*, the initial sketch and core material of *Wild with Blue* is the clarinet melody heard during the first seventeen bars of the piece. In comparison to the core material of *A Rundown on Couples*, it is much denser. When extracting the 'cells row,' I identified fifty-four separate component cells. Before any more clarinet material was composed, the first seventeen bars of the piano part were added, using instruction from the extracted 'cells row.' My approach differed to the one used in *A Rundown on Couples*, where the piano follows the same sequence of cells as the violin; in *Wild with Blue*, the piano was intuitively written following the 'cells row' of the clarinet in retrograde. Example 3 shows the first seventeen bars of the original clarinet and piano version; the cells numbered to demonstrate the employment of their retrograde order in the piano part.



Example 3: The first seventeen bars of the original version of *Wild with Blue* with intervallic and cell analysis (1 of 3)



Example 3 continued (2 of 3)



Example 3 continued (3 of 3)

As with *A Rundown on Couples*, during the composition of the rest of the original version of *Wild with Blue*, each instrument's 'cells row' was followed when making pitch decisions and intuitively working with the possibilities they presented. At times

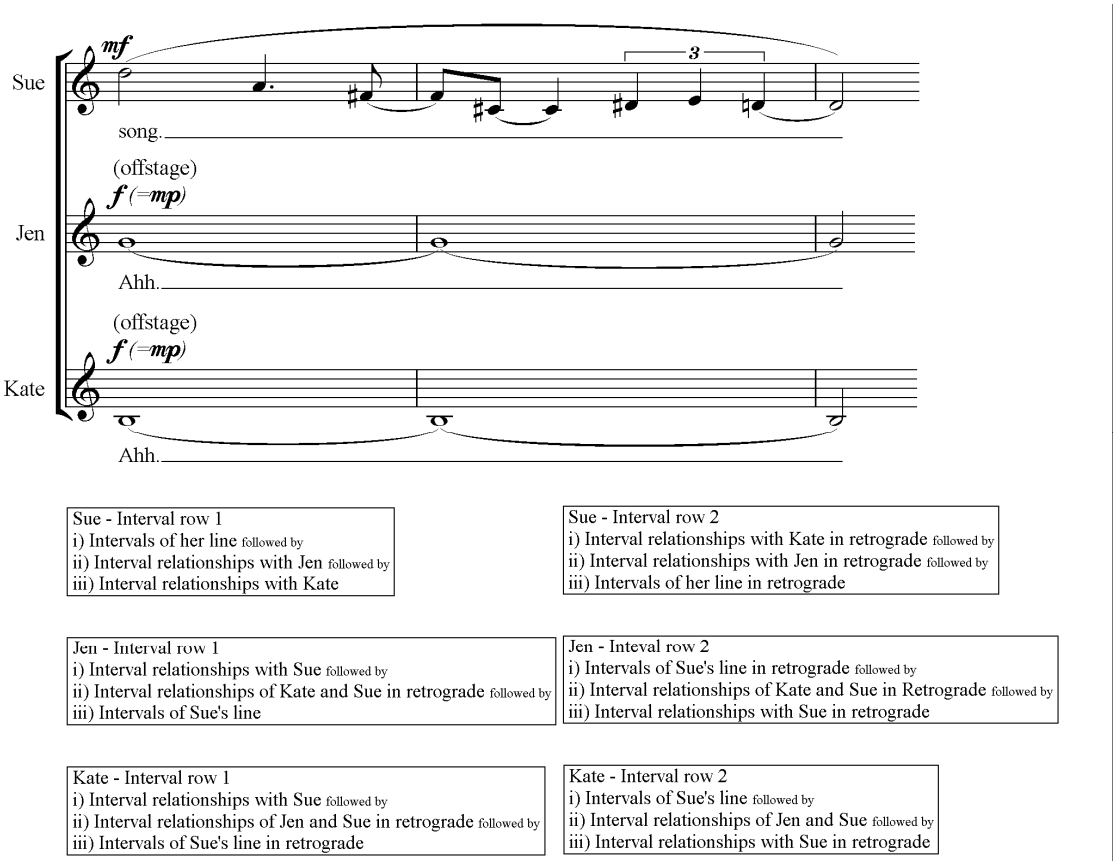
decisions were made in conflict with this but retained the flavours of the intervallic relationships that were established.

This was an incredibly labour-intensive way of working. In an effort to retain a prominent place for intuitive decision making within a unifying process, the vague instructions provided by 'cells rows', in combination with the many available interpretations of them, resulted in a reliance on intuition that was creatively exhausting; the opposite of what I was attempting to achieve.

Following the commission of a piece for alto saxophone and piano for the 2008 Cheltenham festival, I decided to adapt the original version of *Wild with Blue*. The commission demanded a work between ten and twelve minutes in length – double the length of the existing piece. The first task was to adapt all of the clarinet music for the alto saxophone, which chiefly involved moving certain passages down the octave. The music was thinned out; more dialogue between the saxophone and piano was created by the removal of certain lines of counterpoint. This allowed the ideas to breathe. The last task was to lengthen the piece. The original rows were not employed in any way during the extending process. Extension was achieved largely through repetition: small sections were lengthened through repetition and transposition (the intervallic choices of the transpositions being faithful to the characteristics of the original music). The process of expansion was itself an extension of intuitive decision making. Musical ingredients were absorbed into these intuitive decisions, ensuring the desired aural unity within all of the pitch material.

The vocal lines in *Brunch,* except for the karaoke-like moments and the internal monologue of bars 618-637, were also composed using a combination of interval rows and intuition that absorbed the flavours of the resultant music. This work demonstrates the most consciously deliberate use of intuition, as the primary concern was that the vocal lines were sympathetically written.

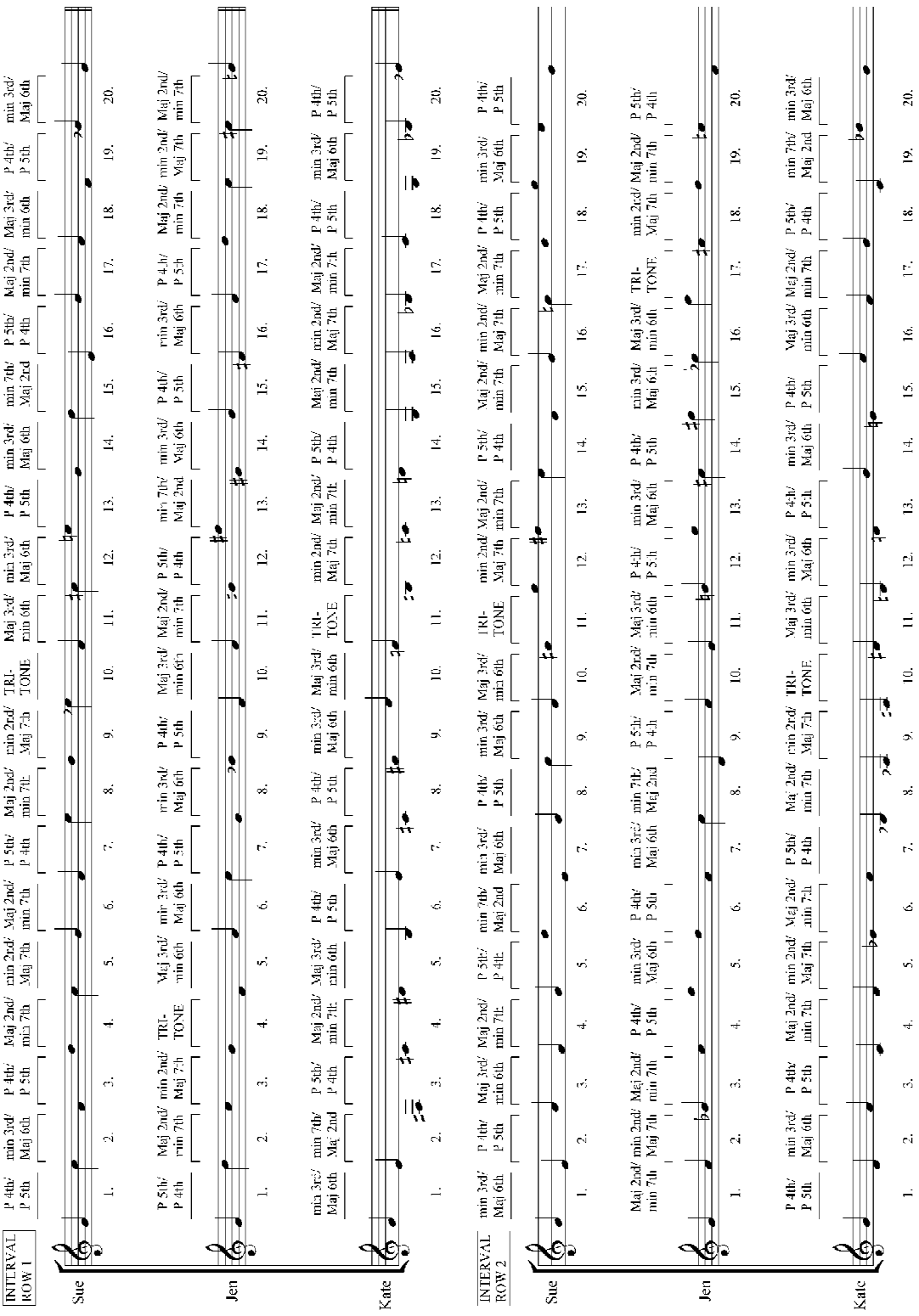
Example 4 shows the core material of *Brunch* and how the interval rows were extracted.



Example 4: The core material of *Brunch*

The music in Example 4 is the original version of bars 12-14. This was later changed, but the material remained, even though it is not heard anywhere in the piece.

Example 5 shows the extracted interval rows, with possible pitches. These pitches are not fixed, and were written only as possible interpretations of the interval rows to assess their use for informing vocal lines.



Example 5: The interval rows used in *Brunch*

I was always aware in *Brunch* that the music had a responsibility to articulate the drama. Leitmotifs are used to partly achieve this; these announce character traits and moods, and were all composed using interval rows combined with intuitive use

of their flavours. The guitar music was also affected by rows and intuition in a slightly different way. It responds to the vocal lines; sharing and disguising melodic material, and its primary function is to assist the singers in finding their pitches. It was written to purposefully sound like someone doodling sections of a piece. It is background music that is essential.

Although intuition played a large part in the crafting of all the music in *Brunch*, it was not nearly as labour-intensive a process as the composition of *Wild with Blue*. This is because there was a pre-determined dramatic structure and shape for the piece, being a narrative-driven theatrical work, which assisted when crafting the music. It always had a definite point to move towards.

Interval rows were next used in combination with other techniques in *The Mysterious Kiss*, which shall be analysed in Chapter Three. Other works in the portfolio that use the technique are *iD* and the fourth movement of *Doodles* – *Um(,)cha(-cha)*. The former combines music informed by interval rows – extracted from improvised material in the opening thirty-seven bars – with parts of an existing bass line of a song from a musical that I composed in 2002. *Um(,)cha(-cha)* uses the technique exclusively. The use of it in both these works differs from any previous treatment, in that it is stricter. The 'tonality' of intervals is a fixed parameter, but the directionality remains free, as does the choice between the original interval or its inversion. For example, a major third can either be interpreted as a major third or a minor sixth, in any direction, but not a minor third or major sixth.

The reason for this more stringent use in *Um(,)cha(-cha)* was the nature of the opening improvised music. It had a quality that was strongly identifiable, and it was substantial in length. About a third of the piece had in fact been written through improvisation, and preserving its character exactly was the most appropriate way of using interval rows to complete this short work. There was also a period of two years between improvising the opening and composing the rest of the piece.

The four rows were extracted from bars 1-38: the two linear trumpet lines and the vertical intervals between the trumpets were over sixty intervals in length each, and the linear trombone line was over thirty. The vertical row elicited, and its retrograde version, continued to inform the relationship between the two trumpets and also that of the horn and tuba. The trumpets and trombone followed their rows in order, and then in retrograde, before the process began again. The horn line is made from portions of both trumpet rows at different times; a decision made through experimentation.

Interval rows in combination with intuitive decisions, made after absorbing their qualities, do, I believe, ensure aural unity within pitch material due to their ubiquitous nature. Application of them exclusively is appropriate when extending improvisations into short, formally composed works. I have not yet found a way to glean any large-scale structural implications from interval rows, and thus when composing larger works a reliance on intuition is needed. This is in conflict with their desired function. They remain an effective technique for producing related variants of any material.

iii) Harmony Mapping

a) Origins and basic premise

Compared to interval rows, harmony mapping gives a much greater degree of fixed control over pitch material from the outset. It is an appropriate technique when core material is thought of purely in terms of harmony. Once chosen during pre-composition, harmonic areas in the form of fixed note collections, initially thought of as chords, are mapped onto a decided structure, limiting which pitches can be used in any given section. This forms the starting point for a work. It may or may not adhere to this pre-determination as the piece progresses. In contrast to interval rows, this technique provides a more concrete sense of shape and direction.

The idea of pre-planning harmonic areas is rooted in tonality and functional harmony, where key destinations, such as modulating to the dominant or relative major/minor, and key relationships of a work are pre-designed.

Self-imposition of pitch limitations can provide a sense of liberation, and intuition is given a different prominence than when employing interval rows. The issue addressed by intuition in this technique is how to be as creative as possible – to express exactly what I want to say – with the limited number of notes given. Whereas interval rows were a way of rigorously exploiting the inherent possibilities of complete musical ideas, harmony mapping gives the pitch possibilities with which to improvise and make complete musical ideas. These can then be varied and developed through translation into different harmonic areas.

When building harmonic territories, intervallic considerations are at the forefront of conscious thought; their varying colours and flavours are an ally when moving from one mood or character to another. Linking harmonic choices to moods via intervallic colour has a root in Lutoslawski, but also in Messiaen's approach of linking harmonic choices, in a highly 'idiosyncratic'[56] way, to his coloured hearing synaesthesia. This has been an influence since first encountering his *Quatour pour la fin du temps* (1940), in particular the way he describes the 'gentle cascades of blue-orange…and blue-orange lava flows'[57] in movements two and seven respectively. Choices based on his synaesthesia were also a potent example of linking harmonic decisions to a narrative. My harmonic choices are related to personal interpretations of moods within narratives, each having its own harmony in the context of the pitch organisation in a specific piece. Examples of these are discussed in the next section. As with Messiaen, comparisons of universal moods between pieces are 'inexact,'[58] but their conscious consideration, as Messiaen's of colour, are an inherent part of my musical thinking. Although pitch is the first decision made, it is not the only concern when depicting mood; timbral, textural, tempo and structural choices being considered simultaneously, with equal importance.

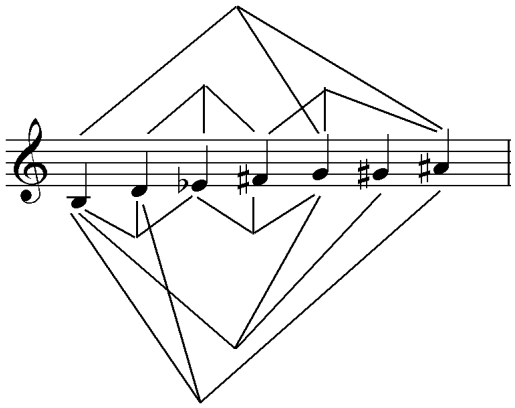
[56] As described by Peter Hill in the Foreword to *The Messiaen Companion* ed. Peter Hill, Faber and Faber (London, 1995), xii

[57] Olivier Messiaen, preface to the score of *Quatour pour le fin du temps*

[58] An examination of Messiaen's colour, as an aspect of his music, and associated analytical issues, including the proposal that '…it is a mystery to be contemplated rather than penetrated' is discussed in Jonathan W Bernard's essay 'Colour' in *The Messiaen Companion* ed. Peter Hill, Faber and Faber (London, 1995) pp. 203-219

b) Uses and developments

Harmony mapping has been interpreted in a variety of ways throughout the portfolio. In *Are we in love?* the harmonic choices are inextricably linked to its narrative, which is concerned with comparing possible emotional conflicts experienced as an adult, to more innocent memories of childhood. There are two pieces of core material: a four bar phrase in F major on the piano (found at bar 56), and a seven-note mode. The piano phrase is reminiscent of a music box and is a representation of childhood innocence, whilst the distinctive major/minor flavours of the mode represent conflict. This mode is shown in Example 6.



Example 6: Part of the core material of *Are we in love?* – a seven note mode with analysis of its major/minor components

For the first forty-eight bars of the piece, these seven notes are the only notes heard, with the exception of C in bar 1 and E in bar 7, as bass notes, and vice versa in bars 45 and 46. The chord that is built by the piano during the last three crotchets of bar 46 also contains E. These are included to imply a structural perfect cadence from the first section of the piece into the F major material – C being established from the outset as the 'tonic' centre of this section, and E implying the presence of the dominant seventh chord of F.

By design, this perfect cadence is only implied – or aurally suggested – as there is a transition passage, beginning in bar 49, where a harmony mapping strategy is used to articulate a metaphor for the stripping away of adult emotional conflict, leaving only innocence. This was achieved by manipulation of the mode; gradually steering

its pitches towards F major. Firstly, in bar 49, A♭s become A♮s. Then, in bar 50 E♭s become E♮s, and B♮s become Cs. In bar 51 use of Gs and B♭s ends, and just before the first introduction of F♮s on the third beat of bar 52, use of E♮s ends, leaving only an F major triad with an added D. Throughout this transition passage, the shape of the F major soprano melody, translated onto the changing modes, was the basis for the contour of the piano line.

As the soprano's character recognises that her childhood innocence is ultimately lost, the original mode is formed by reversing the transition process. This begins at bar 78, and C is re-established as the 'tonic' of this conflict in bar 84. The final gesture in the piano is made from two superimposed 'warped' versions of the F major soprano four-note melody, translated onto the seven-note 'conflict' mode. Whereas this exact material was the point of departure for the transition passage when stated in bar 48, at the end it serves as a reminder of the ultimate destination when searching for innocence as an adult, implying a circular process.

3 Years and *A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario* were both composed using harmony mapping where pitch collections were fixed across their structures during pre-composition, and then adhered to. The core pitch material for *3 Years* is derived entirely from the name of its dedicatee, as shown in Example 7.[59]

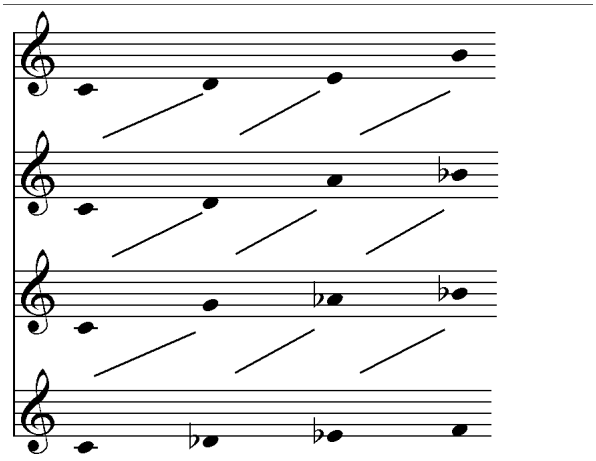


Example 7: The core pitch material for *3 Years*

I do not normally generate pitch material in this way, but in this case it was tried and the resultant pitches were pleasing. The four pitches on the right hand side of

[59] Generated in the manner that Oliver Knussen used the initials LSOMTT as the core pitch material for *Flourish with Fireworks*, as detailed in Example 1 of Julian Anderson's article *Harmonic Practices in Oliver Knussen's Music since 1988: Part I*, Tempo 221 (2002), pp. 2-13, 3

Example 7 are a distilled version, and make up the first harmonic area. Others were then derived by using Stravinsky's method of transposition rotation, as shown in Example 8.



Example 8: Derived harmonic areas from the initial core pitch material of *3 Years* using Stravinsky's method of transposition rotation.

I decided to view these four resultant modes as a single harmonic area for the first section of the piece; the rows explored both individually and in combination to fully exploit the inherent palate of colours. Given that *3 Years* was pre-designed as a four section work, this one harmonic area would not be enough to sustain the whole piece. Three more were needed: one per section. The 'root' of the harmonic area in Example 8 is C, and I decided to transpose it three times to generate the required harmonic spheres. The roots of these transposed versions are B♭, A♭ and D♭; these notes being the inversion of the originally derived row. Example 9 shows the harmonic areas for the four sections of *3 Years*.



Example 9: The harmonic areas mapped onto the four sections of *3 Years*.

By comparison, the harmony mapping in *A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario* was less involved. A chord was chosen to represent each of the six words of the libretto, as shown in Example 10.



Example 10: The six harmonic areas used in *A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario.*

Although originally conceived to accompany each of the six words in the libretto this changed as the composition of the piece progressed for dramatic reasons. These six chords do appear in linear sequence in the above order, with the exception of those

associated with ‘oblivious’ and ‘happy’ interchanging in bars 69-76. Each of the six chords are closely related by design, with notes shared, and changes between corresponding pitches (when reading Example 10 vertically) being of no more than a semitone or a tone each time. The subject matter of this piece struck me as the kind of scenario that might be depicted in a pop music video. The overriding ‘bass line’ of the piece was designed with a pop music-like chord sequence in mind, informing the choice of ‘roots’ for each of the six chords which are shown in brackets in Example 10.

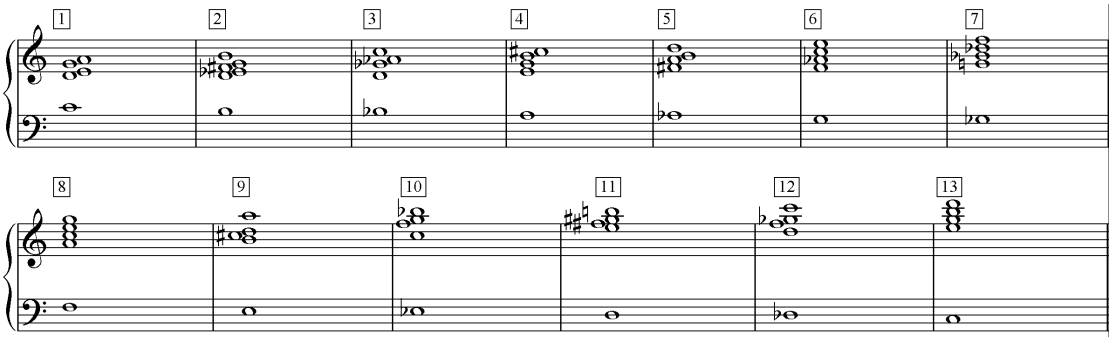
The first movement of *Doodles – Obscuring, black lunar, elliptical, clouds* – was conceived as a series of harmonic areas surrounding a melody that spanned the duration of the piece. Both were improvised and sketched at the piano, and the detail was then added. Similarly the third movement – *Flowers. Grow. Noodles. Mating Slugs* – was initially conceived of as a series of ten chords; found and sketched at the piano. The second movement – *Sea Sick* – is the precursor to *Workplace Diary* in terms of developing a harmonic syntax based on principles of expansion and contraction.

Working with expanding and contracting harmony through intervallic manipulation began during my Masters studies. The culmination of that initial research was *Cells and Sanctuaries*, where a piece of diatonic music, made from a series of thirteen chords, is ‘rediscovered,’ by the harmony of the preceding music gradually opening out from chromatic clusters to the original diatonic chords. These diatonic chords were treated so that each created three offspring. This was achieved by gradually compressing their intervals, going through two transformation stages before finally reaching a cluster of semitones, or mostly semitones; the root of each offspring chord remaining the same as its original. The first movement of *Cells and Sanctuaries* used the linear sequence of all the cluster offspring, the second and third movement the two transformation offspring, finally reaching the original diatonic sequence in the final movement.

A series of chords was not manipulated in this way in *Sea Sick*, but what was explored was harmonic compressions and expansions occurring throughout its duration, in comparison to the sole use of expansion in *Cells and Sanctuaries*. In graph terms, if the x-axis represented time and the y-axis represented the level of intervallic compression, this treatment of harmony would resemble a relationship more reminiscent of a sine wave. The harmonic choices in *Sea Sick* are intuitive and guided by the concept of a 'sine wave' relationship. A cluster forms out of a unison C, and its central pitch changes as the piece progresses. These clusters open out into perfect fifths, and then close back again. At the end of the piece the pitches of the final cluster are swallowed back into a unison C, only to be spewed out in the final moment.

In *Workplace Diary*, this relationship of expanding and contracting harmony with time is explored in a more controlled way. It is the result of combining the intervallic manipulation of existing chords developed in *Cells and Sanctuaries*, with the intuitive placement of expanded and contracted harmony in *Sea Sick*.

The core material of *Workplace Diary* is a series of thirteen improvised five-note chords, and is shown in Example 11.



Example 11: The core material of *Workplace Diary*

Each of these chords was then treated, through intervallic manipulation, to produce three offspring, as shown in Example 12.



Example 12: The core material of *Workplace Diary* expressed in close position, and generated offspring chords

These thirteen harmonic areas were then transposed exactly, so that each of their five notes was at the root. This resulted in a total of sixty-five harmonic territories,

which were then placed in a permanent order: the thirteen harmonic areas loop five times, and simultaneously the number sequence 1-5-3-4-2[60] governs the order of their transposed forms, and this loops thirteen times.

With their sequence established, each of the sixty-five harmonic territories were assigned to a particular character or activity from the narrative of the piece, and these interact in various combinations, as they do in their original context. The manipulated offspring chords are used to represent a spectrum of moods, ranging from negative to positive, represented by the cluster offspring and the original chords respectively, with the two transformations bridging these two extremes.

This latter use of harmony mapping, arrived at following a series of developments, is another effective means of ensuring an aural unity within pitch material, and unlike interval rows, can influence the long-ranging structural implications of a piece. Intuition is still given prominence by freedom within defined pitch limitations, and, when associated with characters that interact, these harmonic areas, already adorned with a wide spectrum of colour through the generation of their offspring chords, can be mobile within a structure and explored in many combinations. Therefore, even though it seems as though much is pre-determined, there is still intuitive freedom built into this technique by design.

iv) Melody Mapping

a) Basic premise

Melody mapping is an approach I have recently started working with in pieces that have two core ideas. Hybridised material is created by a fusion process, where one idea is mapped onto the other at a chosen rate, and these mapped pitches alter those of the idea that they are being mapped onto. The result is that the idea being influenced exists in complete form, but is broken into smaller sections; these sections as a whole move according to the shape of the idea exerting its influence. Both ideas can take either role.

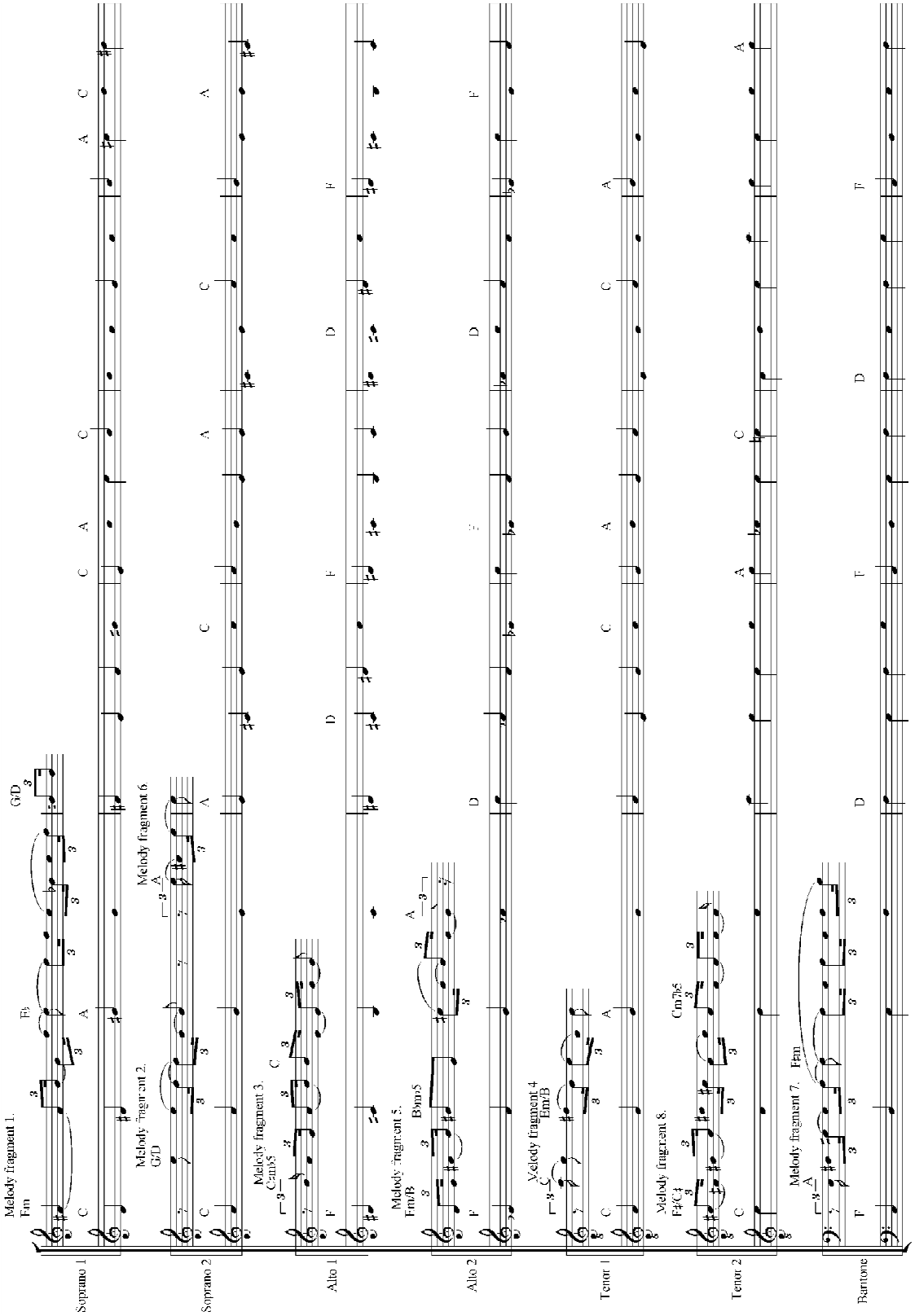
[60] This was my preferred ordering when hearing the notes of the very first improvised chord as a linear sequence, and it was adopted as a strategy.

b) Uses

This technique is used as a major strategy in *The Mysterious Kiss*, and was developed further in *Credo*. The two core components of this work are the plainsong-like/chorale material in bars 65-95,[61] and the jazz material in bars 125-141. The music from bar 65 to the end of the piece was the first composed. A combination of melody mapping and harmony mapping were used to form material for the rest of the piece.

The pitches used in bars 11-31 were derived by taking the notes from the eight, soloistic *improvvisato* melody fragments from the jazz material, placing them in a repeating loop, and then mapping the pitches of the plainsong-like/chorale material onto them. In the original jazz, the *improvvisato* melodies exist within a specific harmony. The resulting pitches in the hybridised material are created by interpretation of the *improvvisato* melodies' pitches as if they are within the key of the name of the pitch mapped onto it. The rate at which these pitches are mapped is the same as the harmony changes. Rhythm is not a considered factor. The beginning of this process is shown in Example 13.

[61] This material continues after this point, but remains harmonically static; oscillating between the last two chords of this core idea.



Example 13: Melody mapping as used in *Credo*. The upper staves of each voice contain their *improvvisato* melody fragments from the core jazz material; their original harmonic contexts labeled. The lower staves show the resulting pitches; the corresponding pitches from each voice's plainsong-like/chorale material mapped, using letters, at the same rate as the harmonic changes in the jazz, and interpreted as the root of the jazz harmony.

Once completed, these pitches were then used for bars 11-31. The altos' lines were swapped, as were the tenors', and occasionally the pitches were changed or swapped around for musical reasons.

A combination of melody mapping and harmony mapping was then used to generate the pitch material for bars 36-53. The last four harmonies of the chorale - A♭, G♭maj7, E♭maj7 and D♭maj7 – were combined with those of the jazz to form a linear sequence of one chord per bar. The pitches of the plainsong-like/chorale material were then mapped onto them at the same rate. Considering everything in relation to E, new harmonic areas were formed, as shown in Example 14.



Example 14: Pitches in bars 36-53 of *Credo* generated through a combination of melody mapping and harmony mapping. The chords in boxes are considered in relation to E, and the same types of chord are then written in relation to the mapped pitches. The labels above the boxed text pertain to other material that informed the resultant music.

As with the previous section, some pitch material was changed or swapped for musical reasons, an example being the tenors and basses switching harmonic areas in bar 53, when compared to the last bar of Example 14.

Melody mapping is a natural extension to interval rows, in terms of my wanted goal of maintaining an aural unity in pitch material. As my works continue to incorporate more than one core idea, often each one having origins in different styles, it is becoming a useful tool when fusing them to create both harmonic areas, which can then be mapped onto a structure, and hybridized variations.

Choosing and Setting Text

My instrumental works portray a narrative; telling character-driven stories through music that will ultimately be interpreted in as many ways as there are listeners to it. A short programme note or a spoken introduction may be offered as a 'way in' to the work for a listener, but ultimately, instrumental music stands alone in terms of any possible meaning or interpretation. The setting of a text, however, has implications regarding a more specific meaning of any music that is created to complement it, because interpretations of the text may influence interpretations of the music. The text itself is also to open to individual interpretation.[62]

I have an 'involved' artistic credo when it comes to setting text. It must have the ability for a dramatic narrative to be constructed around it, and there must be potential for the music to articulate it. Many existing texts, particularly poems, seem complete to me; their narratives secure, images beautifully described, crafted as works of visual art using written language, and also as complete aural experiences when read aloud. I do not feel confident setting such works to music, but equally I concede that whether a work is fit for musical setting is for individual composers' assessment. For this reason I rarely look to existing texts when writing a work that needs one, opting for either collaboration, or to write my own. When I do use existing texts, they are short, and read more as statements of facts or ideas.

[62] See Janet Wolff's essay *The ideology of autonomous art* in Leppert and McClart (Ed.) (Cambridge, 1987), 8

Two such works are *A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario* and *Credo*. The six word libretto of *A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario* – 'Split condom. Oblivious. Happy Father's Day'[63] – immediately suggested the underlying narrative through a dual meaning of the words 'split' and 'happy.' The drama, encompassing the action and the emotional states of the characters, is articulated entirely by the music. Few words mean that the text is not distracting, and prior knowledge of the words could detract from their desired impact.[64]

The text for *Credo* is a statement of belief:

Belief by D.H. Lawrence

Forever nameless
Forever unknown
Forever unconceived
Forever unrepresented
yet forever felt in the soul

The narrative associated with this text is both personal and multi-dimensional, and even though this text is 'complete,' I saw potential for articulating its meaning to me through music, by the use of word painting. The basis for everything, as discussed in the previous section, was the setting of the words 'forever felt in the soul.' This is the complete music; the representation of belief. The setting of the other four lines of the poem are made up of its components, implying the 'completeness in the soul' only when they are combined in a specific way.

The text of *Are we in love?* was the result of collaboration with DH Frost. We have a shared belief when it comes to the setting of text to music. During the process he always wrote with music in mind, and was careful to write words that were

[63] Adapted from a six word story found on the internet. The URL is http://www.sixwordstories.net/2009/03/condom-broken-oblivious-happy-father%E2%80%99s-day/

[64] This was highlighted for me during the two performances of the work at the 2010 Tête à Tête Opera Festival. On the first evening, the audience was not made aware of the six words, but on the second, the words were given out prior to the performance. In my view, there was a noticeable difference in the audience's reaction to the more comedic moments.

'incomplete'; leaving a role for music. The narrative of this piece had been decided before either the music or the words were penned.

Brunch was originally a collaborative project with an amateur stand-up comedian who is not a musician. I had a very clear sense of the scenario and the story, but the words he produced were unusable, apart from the opening lines, and even these needed to be adapted. Having started work on modifying these opening lines, I decided to write the rest of the libretto myself.

Brunch is as much about its concept as it is about the story contained in the libretto. It may be word-heavy compared to my other vocal works but there is not much information to assimilate. Although not a writer, I did have a sense of what an accessible, easily comprehensible, and socially relevant conversation between three women in their twenties could be, and wrote it from this perspective. As a spoken text, I believe it would be banal, but its inherent musical potential was purposefully designed. Characters, moods, and tongue-in-cheek moments are only made sense of when heard in the context of their musical setting.

Given the volume of words, most of this setting is syllabic, in a manner similar to *secco recitative*, and the musical shapes are those of exaggerated speech patterns. These, including accentuations, are always the first things I consider when writing vocal melodies. Barbershop was the style of choice, removed from the sound world of the recitative although still mostly syllabic, as an aural marker for the delivery of internal monologues; tongue-in-cheek, hopefully comedic, moments. The karaoke-like sections are an acknowledgement and parody of both pop music and coloratura aria. These three strands each build to their own climaxes through the entire work.

In *Are we in Love?*, *3 Years*, *A Bit of a Nightmare Scenario* and *Brunch,* rhythms of speech and accented syllables were considered when setting text – even when writing melisma – and translated to appropriate positions within a beat or bar. In *Credo*, these parameters are not always adhered to, allowing the substance of the words in the context of heard language to be disassembled and explored. Examples

include the setting of the word 'unrepresented' in the basses in bar 45; the normally accented syllables switched, and the words 'forever felt in the soul' in bars 91-123 are set in a syllabic loop; accents falling in different parts of the sentence as a result.

Compositional Methodology

Having talked about my primary compositional, and broader musical, concerns, I shall now detail the methodology with which every piece is written, in preparation for discussing this process exclusively from the point of view of *The Mysterious Kiss* in the next chapter. Although the impetus and the relative timings of each of the stages detailed below vary with every piece, the 'routine' is the same. There are four stages: the recognition of a starting point, formal pre-composition, actual composition, then, following completion, revision. The instrumentation of a piece is always decided upon, either by pre-determined choice or by a commission brief, before this process begins.

i) Starting points

a) Narratives

Works with text provide their own narrative. All of the instrumental works in the portfolio were written in response to a personal narrative. Although interpreted from my point of view, the experiences that shaped them are commonplace. A succinct example is *A Book of Firsts*. Each of the four movements was written in response to a first experience, common to all. *A Rundown on Couples* was written in response to an unpleasant professional disagreement. In *Doodles*, each movement responds to the image suggested by its title. *Workplace Diary* is a chronicle of my working day at the job that I took to support myself through this PhD. Inspiration came from translating the ambient sounds and the characters along with their mannerisms and moods.

b) Prose and graphics

Once the narrative has been pondered over and finalized as much as possible, I write it out, making notes about how to represent an idea musically in relation to the

chosen instrumentation. I describe the sounds as I hear them, or 'workshop' ideas in my imagination, then work through the possibilities in prose. This is the first time components of the narrative meet thoughts of sound, and a first draft of a structure is formed. Detailed notes about orchestration, colour, timbre, texture and tempi are made within the sections of the structure that have been identified. Sometimes this is translated into a graphic representation, to guide my inner ear when imagining the piece and visualizing the score. At this stage, I also imagine the performance of the work.

c) Improvisation

Working from either a written description, or a graphic representation, a sense of the temporal shape of the piece is gained by intuitively improvising at the piano. This helps in gauging the lengths of sections, and identifying potential pivotal decisions later on in the process. I am aware at this stage that the final piece will probably bear no resemblance to the originally drafted structure. Sometimes ideas that are spontaneously improvised will be sketched down for use as potential core material.

d) Identifying Core Material

Core material can come in any form, and it is usually shaped by the narrative in some way. The exceptions are *A Book of Firsts* and *3 Years*. For the other works, it was either a melody, or less commonly, a chord sequence. The formation of the core material for *Workplace Diary*, for example, began with improvisation of the opening pentatonic melody, as a result of interpreting the start of the narrative. This pentatonic pitch collection was then played on the piano as a chord. A further twelve chords spontaneously followed, and those thirteen chords made up the core material. Core material can also be existing music, as in *The Mysterious Kiss*, *Credo* and *iD*.

ii) Pre-composition

a) Unpacking or Manipulating Material

Once the core material has been identified, generating related pitch material becomes my primary concern. The processes necessary to achieve this are chosen based on the qualities of the core material. If harmony mapping is used, all generated harmonic areas are mapped onto the narrative-driven structure in this first stage of pre-composition.

Also considered are the inherent rhythmic qualities of an idea, and whether these can be manipulated through augmentation to have structural relevance based on the chosen narrative. Sometimes structural decisions are made arbitrarily regarding section lengths, latterly involving the Fibonacci sequence, as in *The Mysterious Kiss* and *Workplace Diary*. The more parameters that are loosely fixed, the less creatively flustered I am at the outset.

Where available, smaller rhythmic cells of core material are also identified, and a collection of their variants are written out. Where a specific rhythm is required for a particular idea associated with the narrative, they are intuitively found during this stage. In *Workplace Diary*, for example, one of the represented characters has a 'quirk': she uses, with increasing frequency, the phrase 'this, that and the other.' Finding the correct rhythm to represent this was essential. It first appears in the second violin in bars 180-181, and is shown in Example 15.



Example 15: A rhythm associated with a character from the narrative of *Workplace Diary*

Another consideration during this stage is that a core idea does not necessarily make the start of a piece; it can be something that is gradually worked towards.

Initial mechanical work is completed by hand. Once completed, the sketches are then transferred to notation software for cataloguing and storage.

b) Improvisation

A second version of the piece is improvised at the piano using the generated material. Often, more focused work begins, and ideas are worked through more rigorously. The results are sketched on manuscript in shorthand, and then transferred on to the computer.

c) Sketching

Initial sketches are produced by interpreting the prose descriptions of sections of the narrative (musical character, colour, etc.), and using the generated pitch material. This produces blocks of music, but not full sections of the piece.

iii) Composition

a) Combining Sketches in Full Score

Short sketches, in full score, are then grouped in the order in which they appear in the narrative, allowing an assessment of their interaction, and a first sense of shape of the piece. Through a combination of sketching, improvising, and experimentation with orchestrating described colours and textures, these blocks of music are stitched together. From this point, the music's personality takes hold, and ideas that are in conflict with the pre-determined structure present themselves.

b) Shifting Concepts and Identification of Structure

From a combination of the blocks of realised narrative and the music that resulted independent of it, a new shape and structure emerges, and the original narrative is abandoned. Although it was the initial starting point for most of the blocks, its structure cannot be forced onto them as they begin to coalesce. The new shape always involves giving structural relevance to all the composed blocks through straight and varied repetition. An example of this can be found again in *Workplace Diary*. The original narrative was expressed as a six movement work. During its

composition, however, the structure was modified for musical reasons, and the work ended naturally at the end of the second movement.

I have always struggled with the ends of instrumental works, even during the first stage of writing the narrative, and they take many attempts to get 'right' (I remain self-critical of some). *Credo* has the most satisfactory ending for me, from an aesthetic point of view: it does not have one. The piece loops until the performers decide to stop.

iv) Revisions

During the composition stage, the music is in a perpetual state of revision as a result of my self-criticism. Once completed, however, they are only changed if I have written something impracticable, or if an idea can be simplified. These changes usually occur following a workshop or rehearsal. Of late, rather than being revised, I have re-versioned older ideas by incorporating them into new works; subjecting them to new techniques.

Chapter Three

Analysis of *The Mysterious Kiss* – Concerto for Orchestra

i) Background to the composition of *The Mysterious Kiss*

The Mysterious Kiss was commissioned by the Aldworth Philharmonic Orchestra[65] as a result of my winning the 2009/2010 APO Young Composer's Award.[66] The commission was accompanied by a brief: it must be a 'concerto for orchestra *type* piece,' between twenty and twenty-five minutes in length. A preference for the composition to challenge the players and to start and end loudly was also stipulated.

I attended a performance by the APO on 28th March 2009 and made extensive notes about the orchestra; their playing strengths and weaknesses etc. From the outset, these helped to shape the way that I imagined my own piece. There were three considerations ever-present when composing *The Mysterious Kiss*:

1. To respect the amateur disposition of the orchestra: the need to write challenging music, yet to ensure that the rehearsal process would work towards a polished and musical performance, rather than just a grasping of the notes. This could be the case if the music was too technically demanding. That said I wanted to create a piece that could also be attractive to professional orchestras.

2. The work was to be a concerto for orchestra; in my view, this suggested the incorporation of soloistic music, and passages that spotlighted the sections of the orchestra.

3. A personal desire to write the music that I wanted to hear. At the same time, it must be appropriate for the occasion; its place in the programme and its

[65] The APO is an amateur orchestra based in Reading, UK

[66] Each year the APO invites composers under 30 to submit a small portfolio of pieces and a proposal based on a set brief of their making with a view to commissioning the composer of the portfolio and proposal that impresses them the most.

success as a companion to the other works in the concert must be considered.[67]

Initial sketching was rhythmic and flirted with interlocking rhythmic cells that were mainly derived from dances. The narrative in my mind was based around an orchestral 'dance-off,' each dance fighting for supremacy. I layered rhythms based on the Bossa Nova, Samba, Waltz, Fox trot and Charleston, as well as a rock '8-beat' and a quasi-funk syncopated rhythm. These were placed into separate tempi and superimposed, through extensive use of tuplets, and rhythmic augmentation and diminution, creating a cacophony. This was difficult to render workable without making the piece too rhythmically challenging for the orchestra, so it was abandoned.

Nevertheless, the idea of an orchestral cacophony remained. It was reminiscent of an idea that I had been working on some years before, but had discarded due to the lack of a performance opportunity. It was the first scene of a stage work entitled *Passio Christi*. I decided to revisit this material and make the APO commission a musical response to a series of visual and sound images from *Passio Christi* that were teaming with musical potential.

The images that I wanted to depict musically included:

- 'Arrival Procession'
- 'A voice which sang so sweetly it seemed like none earthly thing'
- 'Gyre burning within gyre'
- 'Petal on petal floated out'
- 'Mysterious Kiss'
- 'The Dark before Dawn'

A new narrative was built around these images. I began working on a prose description that charted the trajectory of the piece, translating each of the images

[67] My piece followed Virgil Thomson's *Louisiana Story Suite,* Copland's *Quiet City* and Barber's *Adagio for Strings*.

into descriptions of orchestral music and how these would coalesce to form a structure.

My initial thought for representing 'Arrival Procession' using orchestral forces was to combine various kinds of celebratory music present at a carnival street scene, i.e. a cacophony made from superimposing strands of contrasting material. I eventually settled upon:

- Fanfares
- Ritualistic drumming and chanting
- Wild, celebratory jazz

In addition, I wanted another strand, to make a total of four. I imagined two possibilities that would be present at this 'carnival street scene': drinking songs and a choir singing a chorale. I opted for the chorale, believing it a necessary contrast in tempo to the other three fast strands.

I then attributed each strand to a section of the orchestra (with the APO specifically in mind) that would lend itself best to that music:

- Fanfares: four trumpets (+/- snare drum, bass drum and cymbal)
- Ritualistic drumming and chanting: heavy brass (horns, trombones and tuba) with percussion (tom toms, and bongo with snare sticks for loud passages, and maracas, claves, bongo with hands and tambourine for quieter passages)
- Wild, celebratory jazz: woodwind and jazz kit
- Chorale: strings

During its composition, the piece took on an autobiographical narrative. The sketches made in response to *Passio Christi* were assigned new roles within this personal story. The new narrative focused on self-conflict, and the gradual untangling of unconscious desires; confusion becoming realisation.

ii) The music and structure of *The Mysterious Kiss*

Despite borrowing images from *Passio Christi* as an initial starting point, the music of *The Mysterious Kiss* bears little resemblance to any of the music for that piece. Most of the initial sketches, however, were derived from one melody in *Passio Christi*. This was the first piece of core material identified, although it is never heard in its original form as a foreground theme in *The Mysterious Kiss*. It is the setting of the first words of the libretto, and is shown in Example 16:



Example 16: The setting of the first words of the libretto of *Passio Christi* – the first piece of core material for *The Mysterious Kiss*.

The next consideration was the length of the piece. I envisaged the above melody weaving through the entire work by means of considerable rhythmic augmentation; each note of the elongated melody defining a section. I took the melody and its tempo of crotchet = 54 and sketched out a rhythmically augmented version that would fill twenty-five minutes. This was an initial starting point, knowing it would be unlikely that the piece would remain at this tempo for its entirety. It was not limited to the range of the above melody. An orchestral pitch range was used, and the augmented melody had an overall upward trajectory; a product of intuition. It resulted in a series of pedal tones in different tessiture, although it was not intended that the music would be harmonically grounded to any of these pedals for the entire length of its section. Example 17 shows the pitches of the augmented version of the core material.

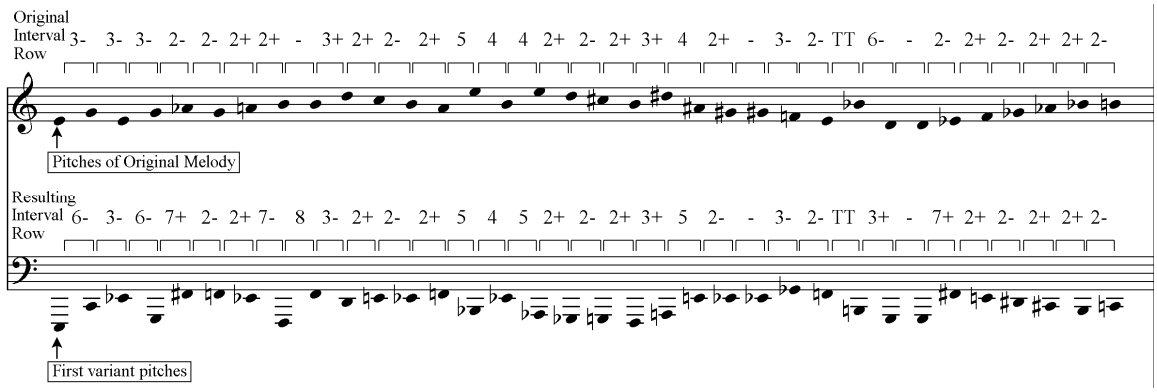


Example 17: The pitches of the borrowed melody from *Passio Christi* redistributed across a broader pitch range

The augmented version was too specific too early-on in the compositional process in terms of defining section lengths. After deciding that it was only the pitches that were of use, I eliminated the original and augmented rhythms from the process. These pitches still influence the work at a slow rate using melody mapping, which shall be discussed later.

Writing out the augmented melody and the series of long pedal tones highlighted the need to link each pitch to the next with variations of the original melody. To achieve this, an interval row was extracted.

The first new variant linked the first two notes of Example 17 together (E1 and G2). It loosely followed the intervallic pattern of the original melody. Example 18 shows the pitches of the original melody, the original interval row, the pitches of the first variant and the resulting interval row for the purposes of comparison.



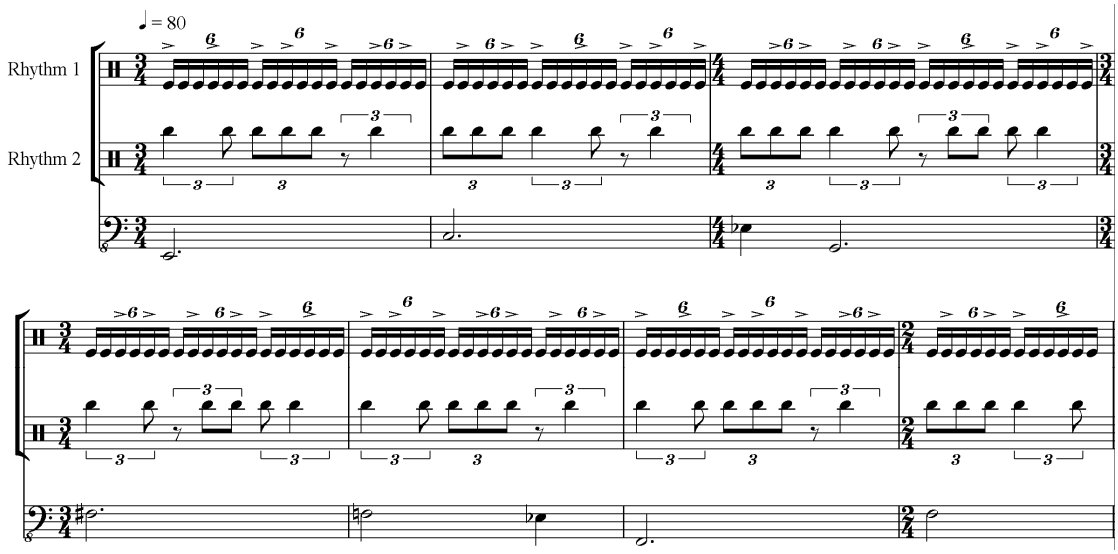
Example 18: Demonstrating how the intervals of the first variant loosely follow those of the original melody.

Once the pitches of the first variant had been established, a rhythm was applied intuitively. In its simplest form it was best notated at a tempo of crotchet = 80, shown in Example 19.



Example 19: The first variant melody including the destination pitch.

At this stage the piece was still a musical response to images from *Passio Christi*. The first variant now provided the basis for the section that depicted 'Arrival Procession.' Composition of the four strands began. Firstly, interlocking patterns for the ritualistic drumming were found. Two were taken from the initial sketches – the interlocking rhythmic cells mainly derived from dances. These were most effective at crotchet = 120; layered onto the first variant melody that was moving at crotchet = 80 through use of tuplets, as shown in Example 20.



Example 20: Two interlocking rhythms moving at crotchet = 120 superimposed onto the first variant melody moving at crotchet = 80

Rhythm 1 is a repeating two-beat (eight semiquavers) pattern (at crotchet = 120) and Rhythm 2 is a repeating eight-beat (eight crotchets) pattern. Sketching of embryonic rhythmic ideas for the wild, celebratory jazz and fanfares, suited a tempo of crotchet = 120. The relatively slow moving first variant could be transformed to move at crotchet = 80 within crotchet = 120 (rather than try to manipulate the music of crotchet = 120 to fit into crotchet = 80). The metric relationship is: a dotted crotchet in crotchet = 120 is the same as a crotchet at crotchet = 80. Using crotchet = 120 as the overall tempo meant that quavers and semiquavers could be used for the drumming ostinati, in a time signature of 4/4. The metrically-modulated rhythm is shown in Example 21.



Example 21: The first variant re-written within the tempo of crotchet = 120

Next to be considered was the harmonic syntax of the piece, which from the outset was to be based entirely on triads with added sevenths. I decided to create modes that comprised of both the major and minor seventh chords; each pair of notes within the original melody as their root, i.e. the notes that 'framed' each section, and started and ended each linking variant.[68] The first section mode would comprise the notes of E major and minor seventh, and G major and minor seventh. This is shown in Example 22.

[68] To clarify, according to this strategy sections one, two and three would have had the same mode (being made from a combination of major and minor seventh chords with roots E and G, G and E, and E and G respectively). The mode for sections four and five would be a combination of G and A♭ (and A♭ and G). Section six would be G and A, section seven A and B and so on.



Example 22: The first section mode, made from combining E major and minor seventh chords (stems down) and G major and minor seventh chords (stems up).

The fanfares material for the four trumpets was intuitively written using this mode. Having explored various four-note combinations from the mode, drifting between consonance and dissonance, it was placed against the first variant at crotchet = 120.

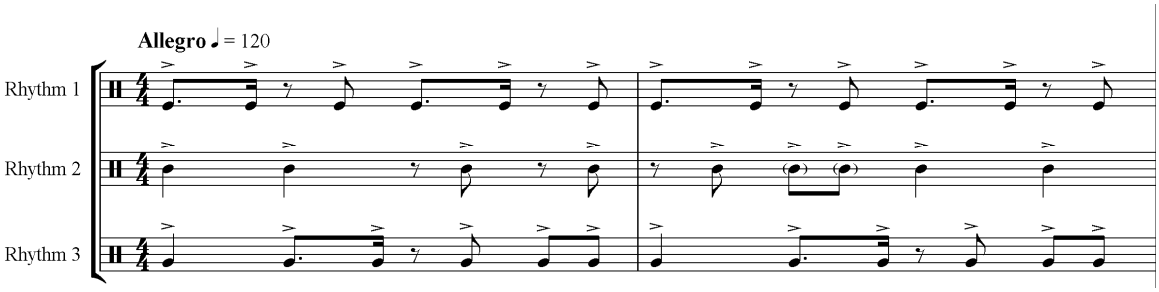
Attention then turned to the wild, celebratory jazz, and during its composition, the syntax evolved. Composition began with a single melodic line over the first variant, using notes from the mode. Notes from the major and minor seventh chords of the bass notes that were not already present were added. To clarify, as a bass note passed that presented the possibility of new notes, these were temporarily added to the mode to give the impression of harmonic movement within the melody. During the second note, for example, C was added to the mode making the chords of C major and minor seventh possible. Throughout the fifth note (F♯), A and C♯ were added, to make F♯ major and minor seventh possible, etc.[69] A jazz-like melody was then crafted using these 'changing' modes that followed the bass line.

At this juncture, the jazz music was set aside and focus turned to the chorale. The compositional task here was to harmonise the pitches of the first variant using only major or minor seventh chords. The sequence was found at the piano, treating each note as a possible root of a major or minor seventh chord. It was then scored for the string section; melodic contour the primary consideration.

With the fanfares, the chorale and the jazz melody completed, the next concern was the heavy brass chanting. This took three attempts to complete, due to conflicting ideas of how to represent 'chanting.' The first key choice was to make the chanting

[69] A clear example of this in the piece can be found in bar 2. The first oboe has the originally sketched melody and from the second quaver, C's are incorporated into the melody. Likewise in bar 3, when the bass note changes to E♭, C♯ appears in the melody (a minor seventh above E♭) which was not in the original mode.

melody that of the first variant. The three drumming rhythms written to accompany this chanting were reduced to the rhythm of their accents, i.e. removal of the repeating, unaccented semiquavers. These are shown in Example 23.



Example 23: The three interlocking drumming patterns from the ritual drumming and chanting music. The bracketed notes in Rhythm 2 were added after the rhythms had been augmented.

These three rhythms were subjected to various levels of rhythmic augmentation. An eight-part (four horns, three trombones and tuba) mensural canon of the first variant was attempted, but resulted in a loss of the sense of line. After further sketching with these augmented rhythms, I decided to employ a new strategy.

Each of the various rhythms would follow the first variant exactly, rather than it being a canon. With every new note in each respective rhythm, it sounded the bass note that was occurring at that time. This meant that for the rhythms containing long durations, the notes were 'spilling over' into the next pitch of the bass line. In combination with intuitive changes, this created the 'fuzzy edge' effect that one hears when large groups of people are singing or chanting in unison.[70]

Once the chanting sketch had been completed, the jazz melody needed to be harmonised. This material was designed to showcase the woodwind. The four trios (i.e. three flutes, three oboes, three clarinets and three bassoons), remained separated from one another; the flutes, oboes and clarinets made conversational; the bassoon given a walking bass line. Dividing the already composed melody between the first flute, first oboe and first clarinet, I harmonised these fragments of tune with straight triads in varying inversions using the remaining two instruments of each trio. Near the start of the tune, when multiple trios play simultaneously, the

[70] This 'fuzzy edge' effect can be seen clearly in the opening bars of the piece, when comparing the horns, trombones, tuba and double basses – the latter entrusted with the first variant proper.

first instruments play the same material, but the other two instruments harmonise it with different triads, creating dissonance. As the tune progresses, they begin to homogenise and conform to a single, unified and consonant harmonisation of the tune.[71]

The bassoon walking bass line is made entirely from the same harmonic process as the original Jazz tune, i.e. the mode plus the added notes with each passing bass note. The pattern that is established on the first note of the first variant (E) is then (broadly speaking) repeated in transposed form, and begins anew with each new bass note. There is the occasional intuitive change.

Material for the first section was derived from the original melody and the first variant in some way:

- The harmonically static fanfares based on a single mode
- The ritualistic drumming and chanting blurred the edges of the first variant
- The chorale was a straight harmonisation using seventh chords of the first variant
- The wild, celebratory jazz woodwind 'conversation' with walking bass line.

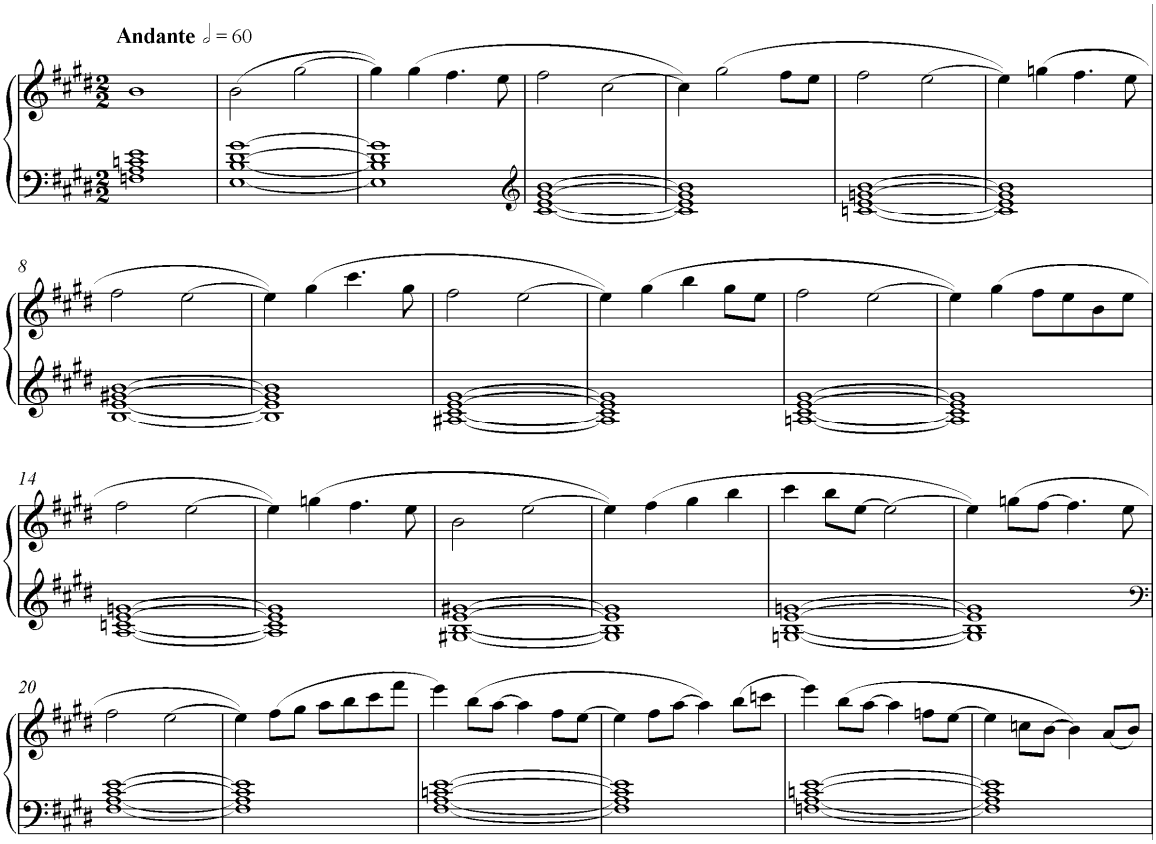
The next task was to superimpose these strands. This resulted in just over a minute's worth of dense orchestral music. I then set about writing more variants of the original *Passio Christi* melody, using the interval row technique, as the bases of subsequent sections. This was abandoned as there was much material already; it was evident that there was enough to craft a twenty-five minute work.

At this point, the interpretation of images from *Passio Christi* was discarded. The four strands of material were teaming with other possibilities. A new strategy was considered. The work could be a twenty-five minute journey exploring the four

[71] This material doesn't appear as originally sketched until near the end of the piece, but a clear example of where the melody is harmonised by three different triads can be found at bars 558 – 560, and later on in that passage, during bars 573 – 580, the harmonisation of the melody is unified.

strands through varying combinations and orchestrations, with the already-written cacophony as its culmination.

In connection with the private narrative, the missing link – a fifth strand of music, and second piece of core material – was added. It was a simple, cyclical 'tune and chords' love song, shown in Example 24.



Example 24: The second piece of core material – a love song (shown here in its simplest form).

Following its incorporation into the compositional strategy, the piece became about finding its way back to the above song. In keeping with the narrative, the song had already been experienced, but its importance was not yet recognised.

The four original strands of music – the fanfares, ritualistic drumming and chanting, jazz and chorale – represent rebellious ideas and ambitions. The chorale represents purity and the love song is used to represent clarity.

It is the original melody, borrowed from *Passio Christi*, which takes on the role of suppressing the identity and meaning of the love song. I began to think of it, and from now on will refer to it, as the suppression melody. It achieves the desired goal in three ways. One alludes to physical gesture, and shall be discussed later. The other two involve melody mapping. All three diminish as the piece progresses; representing confusion becoming realisation.

The two uses of melody mapping could be individually labelled as local and global. Local mapping occurs during sections that explicitly use the love song. The rhythm of the melody remains the same, as does its melodic shape, but melody mapping alters the identity of the tune and its accompaniment.

A sketch was made that consisted of the love song repeating eight times (each in its original key of E major), and the suppression melody mapped on to it at varying rates; itself repeating in a loop. The mapping rates slowed as the sketch progressed, allowing the love song to discover its original form; a response to the idea of confusion becoming realisation. This sequence of love song presentations in this sketch is the order in which they appear in the piece, apart from the addition of two (highlighted below). These were written by superimposing the rhythm of the first variant as the mapping rate, to add a further degree of variation. Example 25 demonstrates the effects of melody mapping on both the tune and accompaniment; the suppression melody mapped in this case at a rate of one note per bar. Tied notes remain, so that the rhythm of the melody is not disrupted. This was the original sketch for Figure B.



Example 25: Local melody mapping in *The Mysterious Kiss*, the suppression melody mapped at a rate of one note per bar

Global melody mapping is achieved by the mapping of the suppression melody onto the entire structure; each of its pitches exerting influence over a section by its adoption as a key centre. Every sketch of every section was, for want of a better phrase, 'in the key of E.'[72] Transposition from E to the mapped note was how this strategy was employed. For narrative, intuitive and structural reasons, not all sections follow this scheme. Those that do not, along with details of all transpositions, are highlighted in the following analytical synopsis of each section of

[72] This is the key of the original love song and the first notes of both the suppression melody and the first variant, so therefore a logical choice.

the piece. The key centres are labelled to assist with the explanation of the global mapping of the suppression melody (Example 17), and its deviations.

Section 1: key centre E

The work opens with the representation of confusion. Both purity and the rebellious elements are bustling along simultaneously. One by one the latter 'fizzle out,' leaving a brief glimpse of purity, before the rebellious elements creep back in. This 'fizzling out' was controlled following arbitrary experimentation with the first eight values of the Fibonacci sequence (1.1.2.3.5.8.13.21). The fanfares break down over three bars, the chanting over the next five, and the jazz over the following eight. Following this experimentation, the Fibonacci sequence was used to control other textural, and also structural, aspects of the work. These are discussed as they occur.

Section 2: key centre G

At Figure B everything is cut off. This is the first presentation of the love song and, therefore, clarity. It is a duet for piccolo and oboe, accompanied by four solo celli, and the music is that of Example 25. The employed strategy of mapping the suppression melody globally resulted in this section's key centre being changed to G, thus transposed up a minor third.

Section 3: key centre E

At Figure C the love song repeats, and the suppression melody pitch mapping continues from the previous section, mapped at a rate of one note per two bars, changing to one note per three bars at the **Poco meno mosso** (bar 61). The **Poco meno mosso** is a structural pre-echo of the climax. By the end of this section, the suppression melody pitch mapping has been through one complete cycle of its thirty-four pitches.

The third, physical representation of suppression (mentioned earlier) is employed in this section. The orchestra stabs at the love song with increasing frequency. The chords are made from the original modes derived as part of the harmonic syntax - modes that comprise both the major and minor seventh chords of each two-note

group within the suppression melody. The lowest instruments of each section of the orchestra (the third bassoon, tuba and double bass), play the pitches of the suppression melody, with the modes scored as chords for the rest of the section. The rhythms of these stabs are the three accent patterns of the three ritual drumming patterns, as shown in Example 23. The brass section follows the accent pattern of percussion I, the strings follow percussion II and the woodwind follow percussion III. These begin in a fragmentary fashion and build through the section to form the full accent pattern rhythms, eventually obliterating the altered love song melody. Compared to the subtle alterations caused by melody mapping, this is a more blatant musical representation of suppression. Example 26 shows the first thirteen bars of these 'stabbing' chords as originally sketched. Each chord is labelled with the two notes from whose combined major and minor seventh chords they are made.



Example 26: The 'stabbing' chords at Figure C as originally sketched.

Section 4: key centre G

At Figure E there is a repeat of the opening, creating the sense that clarity has been forgotten. At the same time this repeat is the necessary musical destination of the increasing, belligerent orchestral stabs of Figure D. These stabs are the various strands of music trying to 'get back in'. The textural breakdown is the same as the first section. The music comes to rest on a still string chord. As per the global melody mapping, this section was transposed up a minor third (from E to G).

Section 5: key centre E (deviation from the global melody mapping)

At Figure F is the first of three sections that showcase the strings. Initially, only one such section was planned; this partly explains why is does not adhere to the transposition scheme. It became evident that three were needed to form important structural pillars because of the radical change of tempo; each marked **Lento intenso**. The material used here is the original chorale sketch.

The role of the chorale material evolved twofold. It provides moments of meditative reflection within the string-only sections. Outside of these, it draws other strands of music into it, bringing a first level of unity to these disparate elements.

Figures G to BB form a large over-arching section, during which the fanfares and ritualistic drumming and chanting are 'tamed' by absorption into the chorale material. Further unity is created as the love song draws elements of the other strands into its accompaniments. Within the two remaining string-only sections, the chorale material also discovers its true identity and purpose.

Section 6: key centre A♭ (global melody mapping resumed from Section 4)

At Figure G, the fanfare material is explored by the orchestra. It starts with a passage that spotlights the percussion section, and the other sections of the orchestra gradually drift in. The rate of textural build is controlled using the Fibonacci sequence. The percussion play for thirteen bars, the woodwind build up over the next eight, the strings over the next five, followed by the heavy brass over

the next three. The trumpets build over two, leaving one bar of tutti. The original version was transposed up a major third (from E to A♭) in keeping with the mapped suppression melody.

Section 7: key centre G

Figure J is the next presentation of the love song, and is one of the two added to the original sketch of eight (mentioned above). The chordal accompaniment has the rhythm of the string chorale, and the rate of local suppression melody mapping is each change in rhythm; the chord types remain fixed as per the original love song. The love song melody is informed by the resultant chords. There are orchestral stabs at J, but with an additional component when compared to those in Section 3 (Figure C). Fanfare gestures are incorporated across the orchestra; these try to find their way back to the trumpets, eventually finding them one bar before K, through a conduit of horns and lower brass.

Section 8: key centre A

At Figure K the fanfares material is presented as originally sketched, although transposed as a result of global melody mapping. In the distance, the chorale can be heard.[73] As the trumpets fumble through their material, the chorale suddenly appears closer, and pulls the fanfares towards its harmony. After a few failed attempts, they manage to synchronise one bar before Figure M.

Section 9: key centre B

At Figure M, the Fanfares, while retaining their rhythmic identity, are completely absorbed into the chorale harmony, which is explored briefly by the whole orchestra. The textural build is controlled by the Fibonacci sequence. The strings change from *sul tasto* to *normale* over five bars, the woodwind build over three, then the heavy brass over two, leaving one bar of tutti. The textural breakdown that immediately follows takes place over two bars.

[73] The effect of 'distance' is achieved by the strings playing col legno tratto.

Section 10: key centre B

Figure N is the next presentation of the love song, and represents the fastest rate of local melody mapping; one per crotchet. The melody (a duet for horn and cello), responds accordingly. The accompaniment figures in the woodwind are gestures derived from the jazz material. The Fibonacci sequence is used structurally for the first time: the section is reduced from twenty-five bars, as originally sketched, to twenty-one bars in length.

Section 11: key centre D

At Figure O, the rate of 'local' melody mapping is slowed, and the orchestra begins to stab at the tune. In keeping with the idea of a lessening of confusion articulated throughout the musical journey, the stabs here are less offensive. They gradually diminish in gestural severity, and synchronise into the harmony. In addition, one of the stabbing rhythms, entrusted to the piccolo, first oboe, third clarinet, third bassoon and xylophone, has the pitches of the love song proper; a disguised pre-echo of the final destination of the piece.

Section 12: key centre G (deviation from the global melody mapping)

Figure Q is the second **Lento intenso** section, for violins only. Here are the first glimpses of this material metamorphosing into the original accompaniment of the love song. It is 'not quite right', but the chords are closer to this than the original chorale. This deviates from the transposition scheme as it was added in the final stages of the composition process; it is a repeat of the violins' material of Section 7 (Figure J).

Section 13: key centre C (global melody mapping resumed from Section 11)

At Figure R the ritual drumming and chanting material is explored by the orchestra. The Fibonacci sequence is used to control the textural build. The drumming first appears far in the distance in soft percussion and col legno strings, and this enters over thirteen bars. Then the chanting enters, firstly in the woodwind over eight bars, then heavier percussion over five, followed by lower brass over three, and then the horns over two bars. The final bar is tutti.

Section 14: key centre B

Figure U is the next presentation of the love song, and is the second that was added to the eight originally sketched. The mapping rate is that of the chorale rhythm, and this follows on from the unfinished chorale rhythm used in Section 7 (Figure J). The stabs have metamorphosed into gentle, consonant and supportive punctuations of the melody. In addition to pizzicato lower strings, the flutes have a pre-echo of the coming jazz section in a three part chorale in counterpoint with the muted trumpet duet.

Section 15: key centre A

Figure V is akin to Figure K, and the ritual drumming and chanting is absorbed into the chorale. Mirroring the orchestral deployment of this material in Section 13 (Figure R), heavy brass instruments enter gradually; the textural build governed by the Fibonacci sequence. The trombones and tuba build over eight bars, then the horns over three. It takes thirteen bars for the percussion to achieve constant strikes of the skins.

The horns in this section first unite in rhythm, and then the single line is transformed into the four-part harmony of the chorale. The lower brass instruments gradually adopt both the rhythm and harmony of the chorale.

Section 16: key centre B (deviation from the global melody mapping)

Figure X is akin to Figure M. Both the Fanfares and Chanting have now been completely absorbed into the chorale, yet retain their identity. The Fibonacci sequence is employed to control the textural build. The strings change from *sul tasto* to *normale* over five bars, the woodwind build over three. There is orchestral tutti for three bars, and then a textural breakdown over two. This section doesn't follow the transposition scheme because a repeat of Figure M, in terms of its key, was more structurally secure.

Section 17: key centre B (resumes the global melody mapping as if the previous section adhered to it)

Figure Y is the next presentation of the love song, taken from the original sketch of eight. A solo bassoon plays the melody, and the accompaniment figures are taken from the fanfare material. The local melody mapping rate is one pitch per minim. The Fibonacci sequence is also employed structurally: the section was reduced in length from twenty-five to thirteen bars.

Section 18: key centre E

At Figure Z, the love song is presented again, as a duet for bassoon and viola (with more violas gradually joining the texture). The local melody mapping rate slows, first to one pitch per bar in bars 429-438, and then one per six crotchets in bars 439-449. The accompaniment gestures are informed by the chorale material (strings and lower brass), the jazz material (three flutes) and the fanfare material (trumpets and horns). The Fibonacci sequence is also employed structurally: the section was reduced in length from twenty-five to twenty-one bars.

Section 19: key centre E (deviation from the global melody mapping)

The **Lento intenso** at Figure AA presents the accompaniment proper to the love song, as a pre-echo of the final destination of the piece. It deviates from the transposition scheme because the material is presented in its original key.

Section 20: key centre B (resuming the global melody mapping, but omitting C♯)

Up until now the fanfares, ritual drumming and chanting and chorale had been explored by the full orchestra. It was not possible to explore the jazz material in such a way as precious rehearsal time would have been lost to, for example, the strings working towards playing in exact, crisp and precise rhythmic unison. At Figure BB, the jazz material remained confined to the woodwind, but a string walking bass was added. This is eventually taken over by the bassoons as per the original sketch. The woodwind section enters gradually, as if being 'infected' by this mischievous material. This process is not governed by the Fibonacci sequence.

Section 21: key centre D♯

At Figure EE, the jazz material is cut off by another presentation of the love song. This directly pre-echoes the end of the piece as the tune is in unison strings, and the accompaniment in the lower brass is presented as a chorale. The local melody mapping rate is one pitch per two bars, and through use of the Fibonacci sequence the section is reduced in length to eight bars from its original twenty-five.

Section 22: key centre A♯

At bar 535 (the bar before the **Poco meno mosso**), the final presentation of an altered love song begins. Its local melody mapping rate begins directly on the **Poco meno mosso** at bar 536, and is one pitch every four bars. The resultant music is a direct premonition of the final climax, as it is in D major. The woodwind stab at it, gradually re-introducing the jazz gestures. The Fibonacci sequence is employed structurally: the section was reduced in length from twenty-five bars to thirteen.

Section 23: key centre G♯

At Figure FF the wild, celebratory jazz is presented as originally sketched, against the original string chorale, although both transposed as per the global suppression melody mapping.

Section 24: key centre G♯

Like the ritual drumming and chanting and the fanfares before it, the jazz material is to be 'tamed'. Final and complete unity of all the material is close. At Figure HH, the jazz begins anew, but the chorale in the strings begins to transform into the accompaniment proper of the love song. The Fibonacci sequence governs a textural build: the strings change from *sul tasto* to *normale* over five bars, the ritual drumming and chanting then enters over five, and following this the fanfares enter. All are harmonically unified. The jazz music is pulled into the harmony too.

Section 25: key centre D (deviation and end of the global melody mapping)

The last chord of the previous section is A major seventh, and this implied a perfect cadence into the climax. The original love song, in D major arrives at Figure II. The melody is played by unison strings. The ritualistic drumming and chanting has transformed into both a chorale accompaniment in the lower brass, and a chanting accompaniment in the horns. The fanfares punctuate within the harmony. The jazz remains rhythmically identical yet is harmonically absorbed into the accompaniment of the love song.

Section 26

At letter JJ, there is one final build. Governed by the Fibonacci sequence, each of the strands is built up in turn; the jazz over five bars, the chanting and chorale over three, followed by the trumpets. Due to the cyclical nature of the love song chords, the final resolution is both the start and end of its cycle: a D major triad.

iii) Conclusions

The Mysterious Kiss integrates all of the pitch-control techniques, and other concerns, that I have been developing throughout my doctoral studies, into a single compositional strategy. Interval rows, melody and harmony mapping, a narrative-driven structure and associated characters, are all present. Intuition also played a prominent role. It posed a challenge in terms of orchestration, given the amateur disposition of the orchestra, and is certainly more conservative in terms of floridity than my other orchestral works. That said, having an upper limit of difficulty as a fixed parameter taught me to express what I wanted in the most direct way. In hindsight, I do not think that I challenged certain sections of the orchestra enough, particularly the horns, and all of the material could have been extended further in its own right, rather than presented as a blending of blocks. The ending is also too abrupt in my view. I could have achieved a more satisfactory conclusion by prolonging the climax at Figure II. With distance, I can see potential for a series of statements, of fragments of the original love song with harmonically unified material, each containing a textural decay or build as found in previous sections. These would culminate in a series of final chords, each prolonging the music's

inevitable consequence. Such an end would be less predictable and more in keeping with the character of the piece as a whole. Perhaps, with greater distance and facility, I will attempt this in the future.

Postscript

My doctoral studies have embraced processes that maintain control over pitch material, yet simultaneously have inherent need for intuitive decision-making. With each successive work composed, there were developments of my compositional voice and desired approach through new experimentation.

Interval rows were explored first, but use of them exclusively in large works represented a dead-end, due to a lack of structural intimation, direction, and thus too heavy a reliance on intuition, even when adhering to structures that were based around narratives. My conclusion is that this technique is amenable to short works, and is useful for generating variations of any material.

Harmony mapping and its varying implications were then explored, with greater success than interval rows, as intuition and structural directionality were an inherent part of the process by design. In conjunction with narratives and character descriptions, the invention and development of material using pre-determined pitch collections allowed both focused microscopic work and a clear sense of their structural place, whereas interval rows just allowed the former.

As the pluralistic nature of my idiom began to affect choices of core material, a desire to fuse two core ideas led to the development of melody mapping. Still in its infancy, I will undoubtedly explore this technique further in future projects. Fusing multiple ideas rooted in personal responses to different styles, to create hybridised music that acknowledges all of these influences simultaneously, will hopefully provide more 'ways in' for a wider audience. The developments of processes that fuse elements of all methods of pitch control are also a creative concern for the future. Attempts to address these issues compositionally began during the latter half of the portfolio, but further development and refinement is needed.

The place and use of my music within the wider musical landscape and society as a whole have been growing preoccupations throughout this PhD. Writing music inspired by 'everyday' occurrences common to all, and perhaps the 'lightening' of my

language through the portfolio, due to the inclusion of core materials in their original forms, as well as the challenging of perceived performance stereotypes are reactions to this issue. The works concerning the latter point – *Brunch, iD* and *Credo* – are, for me, experimental, and I look forward to forging performance opportunities in the future to test my social theories. Particularly of interest is the notion of incorporating contemporary music as a background element in informal social situations, as I do with the jazz ensemble in function gigs. It is not my intention to 'devalue' it, but rather to give it more value through its use and exposure; free of pomp and expectation, and removed from its likely performance context.

Background music, and in particular reactions to its aural suggestions, is one of the inspirations behind *Brunch*. Although a standalone work, there is potential to extend it into a three act opera. I plan to compose a second act for the female characters' male counterparts, set in a pub or bar, and instead of a guitarist, their 'background' will be an invented radio programme to which their vocal music will respond. A third 'show down' act, between the two groups, will take place in a restaurant; a combination of pre-recorded electronic music and a live ensemble providing the background components.

With unparalleled musicality and technical facility, working with professional musicians is the most rewarding way to experience one's music in performance. Economic and political forces dictate that these opportunities are few, rare and brief. Working with dedicated amateurs is a valuable way to practice one's craft and continue to develop all aspects of one's musicality, as I discovered with *The Mysterious Kiss*. Collaborating with interested amateur musicians, including orchestras but also folk, jazz, rock and vocal groups, on pluralistic projects and performing them in a variety of contexts is worthy of exploration. In parallel, forging working relationships with professional ensembles is an ongoing, vital process. Ultimately, I must continue to express my ideas through composition, share them through performance, and never stop learning through doing.

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